

As she spoke she infused fresh vigour into him, and when he had prayed to her he poised his spear and hurled it. He hit Eupeithes' helmet, and the spear went right through it, for the helmet stayed it not, and his armour rang rattling round him as he fell heavily to the ground. Meantime Ulysses and his son fell the front line of the foe and smote them with their swords and spears; indeed, they would have killed every one of them, and prevented them from ever getting home again, only Minerva raised her voice aloud, and made every one pause. "Men of Ithaca," she cried, cease this dreadful war, and settle the matter at once without further bloodshed."

On this pale fear seized every one; they were so frightened that their arms dropped from their hands and fell upon the ground at the sound of the goddess's voice, and they fled back to the city for their lives. But Ulysses gave a great cry, and gathering himself together swooped down like a soaring eagle. Then the son of Saturn sent a thunderbolt of fire that fell just in front of Minerva, so she said to Ulysses, "Ulysses, noble son of Laertes, stop this warful strife, or Jove will be angry with you."

Thus spoke Minerva, and Ulysses obeyed her gladly. Then Minerva assumed the form and voice of Mentor, and presently made a covenant of peace between the two contending parties.

MEDEA

Euripides (ca. 484-ca.407 B.C.E.)

First performed in 431 B.C.E. Greece



Image 1.9: Seated Euripides | This incomplete statue shows Euripides sitting down, with some of his works listed on the stone slab behind him.

Author: Jastrow

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Of the three great ancient Greek tragedians (including Aeschylus and Sophocles), Euripides was perhaps the most controversial, and intentionally so. He did not win many of the Dionysian festival competitions

among Greek dramatists with his shocking depictions of wellknown stories, but nineteen of his over ninety plays have survived. As with most of his plays, Euripides' version of the story of Medea focuses on the psychological aspects of the character. Medea, the niece of the sorceress Circe, had earlier helped Jason take the Golden Fleece from the land of Colchis, betraying both her family and her country in the process (including killing her own brother). Medea also had used her magic to restore youth to Jason's father, Aeson. Before meeting Medea, Jason had already abandoned his previous "wife," Hypsipyle, and his twin children with her; the play begins with Medea learning that she and her children with Jason are about to be abandoned for a new wife.

Written by Laura J. Getty

1.5.1 Medea

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Euripides, explanatory notes by Gilbert Murray, M.A., LL.D. and Rhonda Kelley

CHARACTERS OF THE PLAY

Medea, daughter of Aiêtês, King of Colchis.

Jason, chief of the Argonauts; nephew of Pelias, King of Iôlcôs in Thessaly.

Creon, ruler of Corinth. Aegeus, King of Athens. Nurse of Medea.

Two Children of Jason and Medea. Attendant on the children.

A Messenger.

Chorus of Corinthian Women, with their Leader. Soldiers and Attendants.

*The scene is laid in Corinth.*²³

The Scene represents the front of Medea's House in Corinth. A road to the right leads towards the royal castle, one on the left to the harbour. The Nurse is discovered alone.

NURSE

Would God no Argo²⁴ e'er had winged the seas

To Colchis²⁵ through the blue Symplêgades:²⁶

No shaft of riven²⁷ pine in Pêlion's²⁸ glen

Shaped that first oar-blade in the hands of men

Valiant, who won, to save King Pelias' vow,

The fleece All-golden! Never then, I trow,²⁹

Mine own princess,³⁰ her spirit wounded sore

With love of Jason, to the encastled³¹ shore

Had sailed of old Iôlcôs:³² never wrought

The daughters of King Pelias, knowing not,
To spill their father's life:³³ nor fled in fear,
Hunted for that fierce sin, to Corinth here
With Jason and her babes. This folk at need
Stood friend to her, and she in word and deed
Served alway Jason. Surely this doth bind,
Through all ill days, the hurts of humankind,
When man and woman in one music move.
But now, the world is angry, and true love
Sick as with poison. Jason doth forsake
My mistress and his own two sons, to make
His couch in a king's chamber. He must wed:³⁴
Wed with this Creon's child, who now is head
And chief of Corinth. Wherefore sore betrayed
Medea calleth up the oath they made,
They two, and wakes the claspèd hands again,
The troth surpassing speech, and cries amain³⁵
On God in heaven to mark the end, and how
Jason hath paid his debt.
All fasting now
And cold, her body yielded up to pain,
Her days a waste of weeping, she hath lain,
Since first she knew that he was false. Her eyes
Are lifted not; and all her visage lies
In the dust. If friends will speak, she hears no more
Than some dead rock or wave that beats the shore:
Only the white throat in a sudden shame
May writhe, and all alone she moans the name
Of father, and land, and home, forsook that day

For this man's sake, who casteth her away.
Not to be quite shut out from home . . . alas,
She knoweth now how rare a thing that was!
Methinks she hath a dread, not joy, to see
Her children near. 'Tis this that maketh me
Most tremble, lest she do I know not what.
Her heart is no light thing, and useth not
To brook much wrong. I know that woman, aye,
And dread her! Will she creep alone to die
Bleeding in that old room, where still is laid
Lord Jason's bed? She hath for that a blade
Made keen.³⁶ Or slay the bridegroom and the king,
And win herself God knows what direr thing?
'Tis a fell spirit. Few, I ween,³⁷ shall stir
Her hate unscathed, or lightly humble her.
Ha! 'Tis the children from their games again,
Rested and gay; and all their mother's pain
Forgotten! Young lives ever turn from gloom!
[*The Children and their Attendant*³⁸ *come in.*]

ATTENDANT

Thou ancient treasure of my lady's room,
What mak'st thou here before the gates alone,
And alway turning on thy lips some moan
Of old mischances? Will our mistress be
Content, this long time to be left by thee?

NURSE

Grey³⁹ guard of Jason's children, a good thrall
Hath his own grief, if any hurt befall
His masters. Aye, it holds one's heart! . . .

Meseems⁴⁰

I have strayed out so deep in evil dreams,

I longed to rest me here alone, and cry

Medea's wrongs to this still Earth and Sky.⁴¹

ATTENDANT

How? Are the tears yet running in her eyes?

NURSE

'Twere good to be like thee! . . . Her sorrow lies

Scarce wakened yet, not half its perils wrought.

ATTENDANT

Mad spirit! . . . if a man may speak his thought

Of masters mad.—And nothing in her ears

Hath sounded yet of her last cause for tears!

[He moves towards the house, but the Nurse checks him.]

NURSE

What cause, old man? . . . Nay, grudge me not one word.

ATTENDANT

'Tis nothing. Best forget what thou hast heard.

NURSE

Nay, housemate, by thy beard! Hold it not hid

From me. . . . I will keep silence if thou bid.

ATTENDANT

I heard an old man talking, where he sate

At draughts in the sun, beside the fountain gate,

And never thought of me, there standing still

Beside him. And he said, 'Twas Creon's will,

Being lord of all this land, that she be sent,

And with her her two sons, to banishment.

Maybe 'tis all false. For myself, I know

No further, and I would it were not so.

NURSE

Jason will never bear it —his own sons

Banished,—however hot his anger runs

Against their mother!

ATTENDANT

Old love burneth low

When new love wakes, men say. He is not now

Husband nor father here, nor any kin.

NURSE

But this is ruin! New waves breaking in

To wreck us, ere we are righted from the old!

ATTENDANT

Well, hold thy peace. Our mistress will be told

All in good time. Speak thou no word hereof.

NURSE

My babes! What think ye of your father's love?

God curse him not, he is my master still:

But, oh, to them that loved him, 'tis an ill

Friend. . . .

ATTENDANT

And what man on earth is different? How?

Hast thou lived all these years, and learned but now

That every man more loveth his own head

Than other men's? He dreameth of the bed

Of this new bride, and thinks not of his sons.

NURSE

Go: run into the house, my little ones:

All will end happily! . . . Keep them apart:

Let not their mother meet them while her heart

Is darkened. Yester night I saw a flame

Stand in her eye, as though she hated them,

And would I know not what. For sure her wrath

Will never turn nor slumber, till she hath . . .

Go: and if some must suffer, may it be

Not we who love her, but some enemy!

Voice (*within*).

Oh shame and pain: O woe is me!

Would I could die in my misery!

[*The Children and the Attendant go in.*]

NURSE

Ah, children, hark! She moves again

Her frozen heart, her sleeping wrath.

In, quick! And never cross her path,

Nor rouse that dark eye in its pain;

That fell sea-spirit, and the dire

Spring of a will untaught, unbowed.

Quick, now!—Methinks this weeping cloud

Hath in its heart some thunder-fire,

Slow gathering, that must flash ere long.

I know not how, for ill or well,

It turns, this uncontrollable

Tempestuous spirit, blind with wrong.

Voice (*within*).

Have I not suffered? Doth it call

No tears? . . . Ha, ye beside the wall

Unfathered children, God hate you

As I am hated, and him, too,

That gat you, and this house and all!

NURSE

For pity! What have they to do,

Babes, with their father's sin? Why call

Thy curse on these? . . . Ah, children, all

These days my bosom bleeds for you.

Rude are the wills of princes: yea,

Prevailing alway, seldom crossed,

On fitful winds their moods are tossed:

'Tis best men tread the equal way.

Aye, not with glory but with peace

May the long summers find me crowned:

For gentleness—her very sound

Is magic, and her usages.

All wholesome: but the fiercely great

Hath little music on his road,

And falleth, when the hand of God

Shall move, most deep and desolate.

[During the last words the Leader of the Chorus⁴² has entered. Other women follow her.]

LEADER

I heard a voice and a moan,

A voice of the eastern seas:

Hath she found not yet her ease?

Speak, O agèd one.

For I stood afar at the gate,

And there came from within a cry,

And wailing desolate.

Ah, no more joy have I,

For the griefs this house doth see,

And the love it hath wrought in me.

NURSE

There is no house! 'Tis gone. The lord

Seeketh a prouder⁴³ bed: and she

Wastes in her chamber, not one word

Will hear of care or charity.

Voice (*within*).

O Zeus, O Earth, O Light,

Will the fire not stab my brain?

What profiteth living? Oh,

Shall I not lift the slow

Yoke, and let Life go,

As a beast out in the night,

To lie, and be rid of pain?

CHORUS

Some Women

A.

“O Zeus, O Earth, O Light:”

The cry of a bride forlorn

Heard ye, and wailing born

Of lost delight?

B.

Why weariest thou this day,

Wild heart, for the bed abhorrèd,

The cold bed in the clay?

Death cometh though no man pray,

Ungarlanded, un-adorèd.

Call him not thou.

C.

If another's arms be now

Where thine have been,

On his head be the sin:

Rend not thy brow!

D.

All that thou sufferest,

God seeth: Oh, not so sore

Waste nor weep for the breast

That was thine of yore.

Voice (*within*).

Virgin of Righteousness,

Virgin of hallowed Troth,^{[44](#)}

Ye marked me when with an oath

I bound him; mark no less

That oath's end. Give me to see

Him and his bride, who sought

My grief when I wronged her not,

Broken in misery,

And all her house. . . . O God,

My mother's home, and the dim

Shore that I left for him,

And the voice of my brother's blood. . . .^{[45](#)}

NURSE

Oh, wild words! Did ye hear her cry

To them that guard man's faith forsworn,

Themis and Zeus? . . . This wrath new-born

Shall make mad workings ere it die.

CHORUS

Other Women.

A.

Would she but come to seek
Our faces, that love her well,
And take to her heart the spell
Of words that speak?

B.

Alas for the heavy hate
And anger that burneth ever!
Would it but now abate,
Ah God, I love her yet.
And surely my love's endeavour
Shall fail not here.

C.

Go: from that chamber drear
Forth to the day
Lead her, and say, Oh, say
That we love her dear.

D.

Go, lest her hand be hard
On the innocent: Ah, let be!
For her grief moves hitherward,
Like an angry sea.

NURSE

That will I: though what words of mine
Or love shall move her? Let them lie
With the old lost labours! . . . Yet her eye—
Know ye the eyes of the wild kine,
The lion flash that guards their brood?
So looks she now if any thrall

Speak comfort, or draw near at all

My mistress in her evil mood.

[*The Nurse goes into the house.*]

CHORUS

A Woman

Alas, the bold blithe bards of old⁴⁶

That all for joy their music made,

For feasts and dancing manifold,

That Life might listen and be glad.

But all the darkness and the wrong,

Quick deaths and dim heart-aching things,

Would no man ease them with a song

Or music of a thousand strings?

Then song had served us in our need.

What profit, o'er the banquet's swell

That lingering cry that none may heed?

The feast hath filled them: all is well!

Others.

I heard a song, but it comes no more.

Where the tears ran over:

A keen cry but tired, tired:

A woman's cry for her heart's desired,

For a traitor's kiss and a lost lover.

But a prayer, methinks, yet riseth sore

To God, to Faith, God's ancient daughter—

The Faith that over sundering seas

Drew her to Hellas, and the breeze

Of midnight shivered, and the door

Closed of the salt unsounded water.

[During the last words Medea has come out from the house.]

MEDEA

Women of Corinth, I am come to show

My face, lest ye despise me. For I know

Some heads stand high and fail not, even at night

Alone—far less like this, in all men's sight:

And we, who study not our wayfarings

But feel and cry—Oh we are drifting things,

And evil! For what truth is in men's eyes,

Which search no heart, but in a flash despise

A strange face, shuddering back from one that ne'er

Hath wronged them? . . . Sure, far-comers anywhere,

I know, must bow them and be gentle. Nay,

A Greek himself men praise not, who alway

Should seek his own will recking not. . . . But I—

This thing undreamed of, sudden from on high,

Hath sapped my soul: I dazzle where I stand,

The cup of all life shattered in my hand,

Longing to die—O friends! He, even he,

Whom to know well was all the world to me,

The man I loved, hath proved most evil.—Oh,

Of all things upon earth that bleed and grow,

A herb most bruised is woman.⁴⁷ We must pay

Our store of gold, hoarded for that one day,

To buy us some man's love; and lo, they bring

A master of our flesh! There comes the sting

Of the whole shame. And then the jeopardy,

For good or ill, what shall that master be;

Reject she cannot: and if he but stays

His suit, 'tis shame on all that woman's days.
So thrown amid new laws, new places, why,
'Tis magic she must have, or prophecy—
Home never taught her that—how best to guide
Toward peace this thing that sleepeth at her side.
And she who, labouring long, shall find some way
Whereby her lord may bear with her, nor fray
His yoke too fiercely, blessed is the breath
That woman draws! Else, let her pray for death.
Her lord, if he be wearied of the face
Withindoors, gets him forth; some merrier place
Will ease his heart: but she waits on, her whole
Vision enchained on a single soul.
And then, forsooth, 'tis they that face the call
Of war, while we sit sheltered, hid from all
Peril!—False mocking! Sooner would I stand
Three times to face their battles, shield in hand,
Than bear one child.
But peace! There cannot be
Ever the same tale told of thee and me.
Thou hast this city, and thy father's home,
And joy of friends, and hope in days to come:
But I, being citiless, am cast aside
By him that wedded me, a savage bride
Won in far seas and left—no mother near,
No brother, not one kinsman anywhere
For harbour in this storm. Therefore of thee
I ask one thing. If chance yet ope to me
Some path, if even now my hand can win

Strength to requite this Jason for his sin,
Betray me not! Oh, in all things but this,
I know how full of fears a woman is,
And faint at need, and shrinking from the light
Of battle: but once spoil her of her right
In man's love, and there moves, I warn thee well,
No bloodier spirit between heaven and hell.

LEADER

I will betray thee not. It is but just,
Thou smite him.—And that weeping in the dust
And stormy tears, how should I blame them? . . .

Stay:

'Tis Creon, lord of Corinth, makes his way
Hither, and bears, methinks, some word of weight.

Enter from the right Creon, the King, with armed Attendants.

CREON

Thou woman sullen-eyed and hot with hate
Against thy lord, Medea, I here command
That thou and thy two children from this land
Go forth to banishment. Make no delay:
Seeing ourselves, the King, are come this day
To see our charge fulfilled; nor shall again
Look homeward ere we have led thy children twain
And thee beyond our realm's last boundary.

MEDEA

Lost! Lost!
Mine haters at the helm with sail flung free
Pursuing; and for us no beach nor shore
In the endless waters! . . . Yet, though stricken sore,

I still will ask thee, for what crime, what thing

Unlawful, wilt thou cast me out, O King?

CREON

What crime? I fear thee, woman—little need

To cloak my reasons—lest thou work some deed

Of darkness on my child. And in that fear

Reasons enough have part. Thou comest here

A wise-woman confessed, and full of lore

In unknown ways of evil.⁴⁸ Thou art sore

In heart, being parted from thy lover's arms.

And more, thou hast made menace . . . so the alarms

But now have reached mine ear . . . on bride and groom,

And him who gave the bride, to work thy doom

Of vengeance. Which, ere yet it be too late,

I sweep aside. I choose to earn thine hate

Of set will now, not palter with the mood

Of mercy, and hereafter weep in blood.

MEDEA

'Tis not the first nor second time, O King,

That fame hath hurt me, and come nigh to bring

My ruin. . . . How can any man, whose eyes

Are wholesome, seek to rear his children wise

Beyond men's wont? Much helplessness in arts

Of common life, and in their townsmen's hearts

Envy deep-set . . . so much their learning brings!

Come unto fools with knowledge of new things,

They deem it vanity, not knowledge. Aye,

And men that erst for wisdom were held high,

Feel thee a thorn to fret them, privily

Held higher than they. So hath it been with me.

A wise-woman I am; and for that sin

To divers ill names men would pen me in;

A seed of strife; an eastern dreamer; one

Of brand not theirs; one hard to play upon . . .

Ah, I am not so wondrous wise!—And now,

To thee, I am terrible! What fearest thou?

What dire deed? Do I tread so proud a path—

Fear me not thou!—that I should brave the wrath

Of princes? Thou: what has thou ever done

To wrong me? Granted thine own child to one

Whom thy soul chose.—Ah, *him* out of my heart

I hate; but thou, meseems, hast done thy part

Not ill. And for thine houses' happiness

I hold no grudge. Go: marry, and God bless

Your issues. Only suffer me to rest

Somewhere within this land. Though sore oppressed,

I will be still, knowing mine own defeat.

CREON

Thy words be gentle: but I fear me yet

Lest even now there creep some wickedness

Deep hid within thee. And for that the less

I trust thee now than ere these words began.

A woman quick of wrath, aye, or a man,

Is easier watching than the cold and still.

Up, straight, and find thy road! Mock not my will

With words. This doom is passed beyond recall;

Nor all thy crafts shall help thee, being withal

My manifest foe, to linger at my side.

Medea (*suddenly throwing herself down and clinging to Creon*).

Oh, by thy knees! By that new-wedded bride . . .

CREON

‘Tis waste of words. Thou shalt not weaken me.

MEDEA

Wilt hunt me? Spurn me when I kneel to thee?

CREON

‘Tis mine own house that kneels to me, not thou.

MEDEA

Home, my lost home, how I desire thee now!

CREON

And I mine, and my child, beyond all things.

MEDEA

O Loves of man, what curse is on your wings!

CREON

Blessing or curse, ‘tis as their chances flow.

MEDEA

Remember, Zeus, the cause of all this woe!

CREON

Oh, rid me of my pains! Up, get thee gone!

MEDEA

What would I with thy pains? I have mine own.^{[49](#)}

CREON

Up: or, ‘fore God, my soldiers here shall fling . . .

MEDEA

Not that! Not that!^{[50](#)} . . . I do but pray, O King . . .

CREON

Thou wilt not? I must face the harsher task?

MEDEA

I accept mine exile. 'Tis not that I ask.

Creon

Why then so wild? Why clinging to mine hand?

Medea (*rising*).

For one day only leave me in thy land

At peace, to find some counsel, ere the strain

Of exile fall, some comfort for these twain,

Mine innocents; since others take no thought,

It seems, to save the babes that they begot.

Ah! Thou wilt pity them! Thou also art

A father: thou hast somewhere still a heart

That feels. . . . I reck not of myself: 'tis they

That break me, fallen upon so dire a day.

CREON

Mine is no tyrant's mood. Aye, many a time

Ere this my tenderness hath marred the chime

Of wisest counsels. And I know that now

I do mere folly. But so be it! Thou

Shalt have this grace . . . But this I warn thee clear,

If once the morrow's sunlight find thee here

Within my borders, thee or child of thine,

Thou diest! . . . Of this judgment not a line

Shall waver nor abate. So linger on,

If thou needs must, till the next risen sun;

No further. . . . In one day there scarce can be

Those perils wrought whose dread yet haunteth me.

[*Exit Creon with his suite.*]

CHORUS

O woman, woman of sorrow,

Where wilt thou turn and flee?

What town shall be thine to-morrow,

What land of all lands that be,

What door of a strange man's home?

Yea, God hath hunted thee,

Medea, forth to the foam

Of a trackless sea.

MEDEA

Defeat on every side; what else? ⁵¹—But Oh,

Not here the end is: think it not! I know

For bride and groom one battle yet untried,

And goodly pains for him that gave the bride.

Dost dream I would have grovelled to this man,

Save that I won mine end, and shaped my plan

For merry deeds? My lips had never deigned

Speak word with him: my flesh been never stained

With touching. . . . Fool, Oh, triple fool! It lay

So plain for him to kill my whole essay⁵²

By exile swift: and, lo, he sets me free

This one long day: wherein mine haters three

Shall lie here dead, the father and the bride

And husband—mine, not hers! Oh, I have tried

So many thoughts of murder to my turn,

I know not which best likes me. Shall I burn

Their house with fire? Or stealing past unseen

To Jason's bed—I have a blade made keen

For that—stab, breast to breast, that wedded pair?

Good, but for one thing. When I am taken there,

And killed, they will laugh loud who hate me. . . .

Nay,

I love the old way best, the simple way

Of poison, where we too are strong as men.⁵³

Ah me!

And they being dead—what place shall hold me then?

What friend shall rise, with land inviolate

And trusty doors, to shelter from their hate

This flesh? . . . None anywhere! . . . A little more

I needs must wait: and, if there ope some door

Of refuge, some strong tower to shield me, good:

In craft and darkness I will hunt this blood.

Else, if mine hour be come and no hope nigh,

Then sword in hand, full-willed and sure to die,

I yet will live to slay them. I will wend

Man-like, their road of daring to the end.

So help me She who of all Gods hath been

The best to me, of all my chosen queen

And helpmate, Hecatê, who dwells apart,

The flame of flame, in my fire's inmost heart:

For all their strength, they shall not stab my soul

And laugh thereafter! Dark and full of dole

Their bridal feast shall be, most dark the day

They joined their hands, and hunted me away.

Awake thee now, Medea! Whatso plot

Thou hast, or cunning, strive and falter not.

On to the peril-point! Now comes the strain

Of daring. Shall they trample thee again?

How? And with Hellas laughing o'er thy fall

While this thief's daughter weds, and weds withal

Jason? . . . A true king was thy father, yea,
And born of the ancient Sun!⁵⁴ . . . Thou know'st the way;
And God hath made thee woman,⁵⁵ things most vain
For help, but wondrous in the paths of pain.

[*Medea goes into the House.*]

CHORUS⁵⁶

Back streams the wave on the ever running river:⁵⁷
Life, life is changed and the laws of it o'ertrud.
Man shall be the slave, the affrighted, the low-liver!
Man hath forgotten God.
And woman, yea, woman, shall be terrible in story:
The tales too, meseemeth, shall be other than of yore.
For a fear there is that cometh out of Woman and a glory,
And the hard hating voices shall encompass her no more!
The old bards⁵⁸ shall cease, and their memory that lingers
Of frail brides and faithless, shall be shrivelled as with fire.
For they loved us not, nor knew us: and our lips were dumb, our fingers
Could wake not the secret of the lyre.
Else, else, O God the Singer, I had sung amid their rages
A long tale of Man and his deeds for good and ill.
But the old World knoweth—'tis the speech of all his ages—
Man's wrong and ours: he knoweth and is still.

Some Women.

Forth from thy father's home
Thou camest, O heart of fire,
To the Dark Blue Rocks, to the clashing foam,
To the seas of thy desire:
Till the Dark Blue Bar was crossed;
And, lo, by an alien river

Standing, thy lover lost,
Void-armed for ever,
Forth yet again, O lowest
Of landless women, a ranger
Of desolate ways, thou goest,
From the walls of the stranger.

Others.

And the great Oath waxeth weak;
And Ruth, as a thing outstriven,
Is fled, fled, from the shores of the Greek,
Away on the winds of heaven.
Dark is the house afar,
Where an old king called thee daughter;
All that was once thy star
In stormy water,
Dark: and, lo, in the nearer
House that was sworn to love thee,
Another, queenlier, dearer,
Is thronèd above thee.

Enter from the right Jason.

JASON

Oft have I seen, in other days than these,
How a dark temper maketh maladies
No friend can heal. 'Twas easy to have kept
Both land and home. It needed but to accept
Unstrivingly the pleasure of our lords.
But thou, for mere delight in stormy words,
Wilt lose all! . . . Now thy speech provokes not me.
Rail on. Of all mankind let Jason be

Most evil; none shall check thee. But for these
Dark threats cast out against the majesties
Of Corinth, count as veriest gain thy path
Of exile. I myself, when princely wrath
Was hot against thee, strove with all good will
To appease the wrath, and wished to keep thee still
Beside me. But thy mouth would never stay
From vanity, blaspheming night and day
Our masters. Therefore thou shalt fly the land.
Yet, even so, I will not hold my hand
From succouring mine own people. Here am I
To help thee, woman, pondering heedfully
Thy new state. For I would not have thee flung
Provisionless away—aye, and the young
Children as well; nor lacking aught that will
Of mine can bring thee. Many a lesser ill
Hangs on the heels of exile. . . . Aye, and though
Thou hate me, dream not that my heart can know
Or fashion aught of angry will to thee.

MEDEA

Evil, most evil! . . . since thou grantest me
That comfort, the worst weapon left me now
To smite a coward. . . . Thou comest to me, thou,
Mine enemy! (*Turning to the Chorus.*) Oh, say, how call ye this,
To face, and smile, the comrade whom his kiss
Betrayed? Scorn? Insult? Courage? None of these:
‘Tis but of all man’s inward sicknesses
The vilest, that he knoweth not of shame
Nor pity! Yet I praise him that he came . . .

To me it shall bring comfort, once to clear
My heart on thee, and thou shalt wince to hear.
I will begin with that, 'twixt me and thee,
That first befell. I saved thee. I saved thee—
Let thine own Greeks be witness, every one
That sailed on Argo—saved thee, sent alone
To yoke with yokes the bulls of fiery breath,
And sow that Acre of the Lords of Death;
And mine own ancient Serpent, who did keep
The Golden Fleece, the eyes that knew not sleep,
And shining coils, him also did I smite
Dead for thy sake, and lifted up the light
That bade thee live. Myself, uncounsellèd,
Stole forth from father and from home, and fled
Where dark Iôlcôs under Pelion lies,
With thee—Oh, single-hearted more than wise!
I murdered Pelias, yea, in agony,
By his own daughters' hands, for sake of thee;
I swept their house like War.—And hast thou then
Accepted all—O evil yet again!—
And cast me off and taken thee for bride
Another? And with children at thy side!
One could forgive a childless man. But no:
I have borne thee children . . .
Is sworn faith so low
And weak a thing? I understand it not.
Are the old gods dead? Are the old laws forgot,
And new laws made? Since not my passioning,
But thine own heart, doth cry thee for a thing

Forsworn.

*[She catches sight of her own hand which she has
thrown out to denounce him.]*

Poor, poor right hand of mine, whom he
Did cling to, and these knees, so cravingly,
We are unclean, thou and I; we have caught the stain
Of bad men's flesh . . . and dreamed our dreams in vain.
Thou comest to befriend me? Give me, then,
Thy counsel. 'Tis not that I dream again
For good from thee: but, questioned, thou wilt show
The viler. Say: now whither shall I go?
Back to my father? Him I did betray,
And all his land, when we two fled away.
To those poor Peliad maids? For them 'twere good
To take me in, who spilled their father's blood. . . .
Aye, so my whole life stands! There were at home
Who loved me well: to them I am become
A curse. And the first friends who sheltered me,⁵⁹
Whom most I should have spared, to pleasure thee
I have turned to foes. Oh, therefore hast thou laid
My crown upon me, blest of many a maid
In Hellas, now I have won what all did crave,
Thee, the world-wondered lover and the brave;⁶⁰
Who this day looks and sees me banished, thrown
Away with these two babes, all, all, alone . . .
Oh, merry mocking when the lamps are red:
"Where go the bridegroom's babes to beg their bread
In exile, and the woman who gave all
To save him?"

O great God, shall gold withal

Bear thy clear mark, to sift the base and fine,

And o'er man's living visage runs no sign

To show the lie within, ere all too late?

LEADER

Dire and beyond all healing is the hate

When hearts that loved are turned to enmity.

JASON

In speech at least, meseemeth, I must be

Not evil;⁶¹ but, as some old pilot goes

Furled to his sail's last edge, when danger blows

Too fiery, run before the wind and swell,

Woman, of thy loud storms.—And thus I tell

My tale. Since thou wilt build so wondrous high

Thy deeds of service in my jeopardy,

To all my crew and quest I know but one

Saviour, of Gods or mortals one alone,

The Cyprian. Oh, thou hast both brain and wit,

Yet underneath . . . nay, all the tale of it

Were graceless telling; how sheer love, a fire

Of poison-shafts, compelled thee with desire

To save me. But enough. I will not score

That count too close. 'Twas good help: and therefor

I give thee thanks, howe'er the help was wrought.

Howbeit, in my deliverance, thou hast got

Far more than given. A good Greek land hath been

Thy lasting home, not barbary.⁶² Thou hast seen

Our ordered life, and justice,⁶³ and the long

Still grasp of law not changing with the strong

Man's pleasure. Then, all Hellas far and near
Hath learned thy wisdom, and in every ear
Thy fame is. Had thy days run by unseen
On that last edge of the world, where then had been
The story of great Medea? Thou and I . . .
What worth to us were treasures heapèd high
In rich kings' rooms; what worth a voice of gold
More sweet than ever rang from Orpheus old,
Unless our deeds have glory?⁶⁴
Speak I so,
Touching the Quest I wrought, thyself did throw
The challenge down. Next for thy cavilling
Of wrath at mine alliance with a king,
Here thou shalt see I both was wise, and free
From touch of passion, and a friend to thee
Most potent, and my children . . . Nay, be still!
When first I stood in Corinth, clogged with ill
From many a desperate mischance, what bliss
Could I that day have dreamed of, like to this,
To wed with a king's daughter, I exiled
And beggared? Not—what makes thy passion wild—
From loathing of thy bed; not over-fraught
With love for this new bride; not that I sought
To upbuild mine house with offspring: 'tis enough,
What thou hast borne: I make no word thereof:
But, first and greatest, that we all might dwell
In a fair house and want not, knowing well
That poor men have no friends, but far and near
Shunning and silence. Next, I sought to rear

Our sons in nurture worthy of my race,
And, raising brethren to them, in one place
Join both my houses, and be all from now
Prince-like and happy. What more need hast thou
Of children?⁶⁵ And for me, it serves my star
To link in strength the children that now are
With those that shall be.

Have I counselled ill?
Not thine own self would say it, couldst thou still
One hour thy jealous flesh.—’Tis ever so!
Who looks for more in women? When the flow
Of love runs plain, why, all the world is fair:
But, once there fall some ill chance anywhere
To baulk that thirst, down in swift hate are trod
Men’s dearest aims and noblest. Would to God
We mortals by some other seed could raise
Our fruits, and no blind women block our ways!
Then had there been no curse to wreck mankind.

LEADER

Lord Jason, very subtly hast thou twined
Thy speech: but yet, though all athwart thy will
I speak, this is not well thou dost, but ill,
Betraying her who loved thee and was true.

MEDEA

Surely I have my thoughts, and not a few
Have held me strange. To me it seemeth, when
A crafty tongue is given to evil men
’Tis like to wreck, not help them. Their own brain
Tempts them with lies to dare and dare again,

Till . . . no man hath enough of subtlety.

As thou—be not so seeming-fair to me

Nor deft of speech. One word will make thee fall.

Wert thou not false, 'twas thine to tell me all,

And charge me help thy marriage path, as I

Did love thee; not befool me with a lie.

JASON

An easy task had that been! Aye, and thou

A loving aid, who canst not, even now,

Still that loud heart that surges like the tide!

MEDEA

That moved thee not. Thine old barbarian bride,

The dog out of the east who loved thee sore,

She grew grey-haired, she served thy pride no more.

JASON

Now understand for once! The girl to me

Is nothing, in this web of sovranty

I hold. I do but seek to save, even yet,

Thee: and for brethren to our sons beget

Young kings, to prosper all our lives again.

MEDEA

God shelter me from prosperous days of pain,

And wealth that maketh wounds about my heart.

JASON

Wilt change that prayer, and choose a wiser part?

Pray not to hold true sense for pain, nor rate

Thyself unhappy, being too fortunate.

MEDEA

Aye, mock me; thou hast where to lay thine head,

But I go naked to mine exile.

JASON

Tread

Thine own path! Thou hast made it all to be.

MEDEA

How? By seducing and forsaking thee?

JASON

By those vile curses on the royal halls

Let loose. . . .

MEDEA

On thy house also, as chance falls,

I am a living curse.⁶⁶

JASON

Oh, peace! Enough

Of these vain wars: I will no more thereof.

If thou wilt take from all that I possess

Aid for these babes and thine own helplessness

Of exile, speak thy bidding. Here I stand

Full-willed to succour thee with stintless hand,

And send my signet to old friends that dwell

On foreign shores, who will entreat thee well.

Refuse, and thou shalt do a deed most vain.

But cast thy rage away, and thou shalt gain

Much, and lose little for thine anger's sake.

MEDEA

I will not seek thy friends. I will not take

Thy givings. Give them not. Fruits of a stem

Unholy bring no blessing after them.

JASON

Now God in heaven be witness, all my heart
Is willing, in all ways, to do its part
For thee and for thy babes. But nothing good
Can please thee. In sheer savageness of mood
Thou drivest from thee every friend. Wherefore
I warrant thee, thy pains shall be the more.

[He goes slowly away.]

MEDEA

Go: thou art weary for the new delight
Thou wooest, so long tarrying out of sight
Of her sweet chamber. Go, fulfil thy pride,
O bridegroom! For it may be, such a bride
Shall wait thee,—yea, God heareth me in this—
As thine own heart shall sicken ere it kiss.

CHORUS

Alas, the Love⁶⁷ that falleth like a flood,
Strong-winged and transitory:
Why praise ye him? What beareth he of good
To man, or glory?
Yet Love there is that moves in gentleness,
Heart-filling, sweetest of all powers that bless.
Loose not on me, O Holder of man's heart,
Thy golden quiver,
Nor steep in poison of desire the dart
That heals not ever.
The pent hate of the word that cavilleth,
The strife that hath no fill,
Where once was fondness; and the mad heart's breath
For strange love panting still:

O Cyprian, cast me not on these; but sift,
Keen-eyed, of love the good and evil gift.
Make Innocence my friend, God's fairest star,
Yea, and abate not
The rare sweet beat of bosoms without war,
That love, and hate not.

Others.

Home of my heart, land of my own,
Cast me not, nay, for pity,
Out on my ways, helpless, alone,
Where the feet fail in the mire and stone,
A woman without a city.
Ah, not that! Better the end:
The green grave cover me rather,
If a break must come in the days I know,
And the skies be changed and the earth below;
For the weariest road that man may wend
Is forth from the home of his father.
Lo, we have seen: 'tis not a song
Sung, nor learned of another.
For whom hast thou in thy direst wrong
For comfort? Never a city strong
To hide thee, never a brother.
Ah, but the man—cursèd be he,
Cursèd beyond recover,
Who openeth, shattering, seal by seal,
A friend's clean heart, then turns his heel,
Deaf unto love: never in me
Friend shall he know nor lover.

[While Medea is waiting downcast, seated upon her door-step, there passes from the left a traveller with followers. As he catches sight of Medea he stops.⁶⁸]

AEGEUS

Have joy, Medea! 'Tis the homeliest

Word that old friends can greet with, and the best.

Medea (*looking up, surprised*).

Oh, joy on thee, too, Aegeus, gentle king

Of Athens!—But whence com'st thou journeying?

AEGEUS

From Delphi now and the old encaverned stair. . . .

MEDEA

Where Earth's heart speaks in song? What mad'st thou there?

AEGEUS

Prayed heaven for children—the same search alway.

MEDEA

Children? Ah God! Art childless to this day?

AEGEUS

So God hath willed. Childless and desolate.

MEDEA

What word did Phoebus⁶⁹ speak, to change thy fate?

AEGEUS

Riddles, too hard for mortal man to read.

MEDEA

Which I may hear?

AEGEUS

Assuredly: they need

A rarer wit.

MEDEA

How said he?

AEGEUS

Not to spill

Life's wine, nor seek for more. . . .

MEDEA

Until?

AEGEUS

Until

I tread the hearth-stone of my sires of yore.⁷⁰

MEDEA

And what should bring thee here, by Creon's shore?

AEGEUS

One Pittheus know'st thou, high lord of Trozên?

MEDEA

Aye, Pelops' son, a man most pure of sin.

AEGEUS

Him I would ask, touching Apollo's will.

MEDEA

Much use in God's ways hath he, and much skill.

AEGEUS

And, long years back he was my battle-friend,

The truest e'er man had.

MEDEA

Well, may God send

Good hap to thee, and grant all thy desire.

AEGEUS

But thou . . . ? Thy frame is wasted, and the fire

Dead in thine eyes.

MEDEA

Aegeus, my husband is

The falsest man in the world.

AEGEUS

What word is this?

Say clearly what thus makes thy visage dim?

MEDEA

He is false to me, who never injured him.

AEGEUS

What hath he done? Show all, that I may see.

MEDEA

Ta'en him a wife; a wife, set over me

To rule his house.

AEGEUS

He hath not dared to do,

Jason, a thing so shameful?

MEDEA

Aye, 'tis true:

And those he loved of yore have no place now.

AEGEUS

Some passion sweepeth him? Or is it thou

He turns from?

Medea

Passion, passion to betray

His dearest!

AEGEUS

Shame be his, so fallen away

From honour!

MEDEA

Passion to be near a throne,

A king's heir!

AEGEUS

How, who gives the bride? Say on.

MEDEA

Creon, who o'er all Corinth standeth chief.

AEGEUS

Woman, thou hast indeed much cause for grief.

MEDEA

'Tis ruin.—And they have cast me out as well.

AEGEUS

Who? 'Tis a new wrong this, and terrible.

MEDEA

Creon the king, from every land and shore. . . .

AEGEUS

And Jason suffers him? Oh, 'tis too sore!

MEDEA

He loveth to bear bravely ills like these!

But, Aegeus, by thy beard, oh, by thy knees,

I pray thee, and I give me for thine own,

Thy suppliant, pity me! Oh, pity one

So miserable. Thou never wilt stand there

And see me cast out friendless to despair.

Give me a home in Athens . . . by the fire

Of thine own hearth! Oh, so may thy desire

Of children be fulfilled of God, and thou

Die happy! . . . Thou canst know not; even now

Thy prize is won! I, I will make of thee

A childless man no more. The seed shall be,

I swear it, sown. Such magic herbs I know.

AEGEUS

Woman, indeed my heart goes forth to show

This help to thee, first for religion's sake,
Then for thy promised hope, to heal my ache
Of childlessness. 'Tis this hath made mine whole
Life as a shadow, and starved out my soul.
But thus it stands with me. Once make thy way
To Attic earth, I, as in law I may,
Will keep thee and befriend. But in this land,
Where Creon rules, I may not raise my hand
To shelter thee. Move of thine own essay
To seek my house, there thou shalt alway stay,
Inviolat, never to be seized again.
But come thyself from Corinth. I would fain
Even in foreign eyes be alway just.

MEDEA

'Tis well. Give me an oath wherein to trust⁷¹
And all that man could ask thou hast granted me.

AEGEUS

Dost trust me not? Or what thing troubleth thee?

MEDEA

I trust thee. But so many, far and near,
Do hate me—all King Pelias' house, and here
Creon. Once bound by oaths and sanctities
Thou canst not yield me up for such as these
To drag from Athens. But a spoken word,
No more, to bind thee, which no God hath heard. . .
The embassies, methinks, would come and go:
They all are friends to thee. . . . Ah me, I know
Thou wilt not list to me! So weak am I,
And they full-filled with gold and majesty.

AEGEUS

Methinks 'tis a far foresight, this thine oath.

Still, if thou so wilt have it, nothing loath

Am I to serve thee. Mine own hand is so

The stronger, if I have this plea to show

Thy persecutors: and for thee withal

The bond more sure.—On what God shall I call?

MEDEA

Swear by the Earth thou treadest, by the Sun,

Sire of my sires, and all the gods as one. . . .

AEGEUS

To do what thing or not do? Make all plain.

MEDEA

Never thyself to cast me out again.

Nor let another, whatsoe'er his plea,

Take me, while thou yet livest and art free.

AEGEUS

Never: so hear me, Earth, and the great star

Of daylight, and all other gods that are!

MEDEA

'Tis well: and if thou falter from thy vow . . . ?

AEGEUS

God's judgment on the godless break my brow!

MEDEA

Go! Go thy ways rejoicing.—All is bright

And clear before me. Go: and ere the night

Myself will follow, when the deed is done

I purpose, and the end I thirst for won.

[*Aegeus and his train depart.*]

CHORUS

Farewell: and Maia's guiding Son

Back lead thee to thy hearth and fire,

Aegeus; and all the long desire

That wasteth thee, at last be won:

Our eyes have seen thee as thou art,

A gentle and a righteous heart.

MEDEA

God, and God's Justice, and ye blinding Skies!

At last the victory dawneth! Yea, mine eyes

See, and my foot is on the mountain's brow.

Mine enemies! Mine enemies, oh, now

Atonement cometh! Here at my worst hour

A friend is found, a very port of power

To save my shipwreck. Here will I make fast

Mine anchor, and escape them at the last

In Athens' wallèd hill.—But ere the end

'Tis meet I show thee all my counsel, friend:

Take it, no tale to make men laugh withal!

Straightway to Jason I will send some thrall

To entreat him to my presence. Comes he here,

Then with soft reasons will I feed his ear,

How his will now is my will, how all things

Are well, touching this marriage-bed of kings

For which I am betrayed—all wise and rare

And profitable! Yet will I make one prayer,

That my two children be no more exiled

But stay. . . . Oh, not that I would leave a child

Here upon angry shores till those have laughed

Who hate me: 'tis that I will slay by craft
The king's daughter. With gifts they shall be sent,
Gifts to the bride to spare their banishment,
Fine robings and a carcanet of gold.
Which raiment let her once but take, and fold
About her, a foul death that girl shall die
And all who touch her in her agony.
Such poison shall they drink, my robe and wreath!
Howbeit, of that no more. I gnash my teeth
Thinking on what a path my feet must tread
Thereafter. I shall lay those children dead—
Mine, whom no hand shall steal from me away!
Then, leaving Jason childless, and the day
As night above him, I will go my road
To exile, flying, flying from the blood
Of these my best-beloved, and having wrought
All horror, so but one thing reach me not,
The laugh of them that hate us.
Let it come!
What profits life to me? I have no home,
No country now, nor shield from any wrong.
That was my evil hour, when down the long
Halls of my father out I stole, my will
Chained by a Greek man's voice, who still, oh, still,
If God yet live, shall all requited be.
For never child of mine shall Jason see
Hereafter living, never child beget
From his new bride, who this day, desolate
Even as she made me desolate, shall die

Shrieking amid my poisons. . . . Names have I
Among your folk? One light? One weak of hand?
An eastern dreamer?—Nay, but with the brand
Of strange suns burnt, my hate, by God above,
A perilous thing, and passing sweet my love!
For these it is that make life glorious.

LEADER

Since thou has bared thy fell intent to us
I, loving thee, and helping in their need
Man's laws, adjure thee, dream not of this deed!

MEDEA

There is no other way.—I pardon thee
Thy littleness, who art not wronged like me.

LEADER

Thou canst not kill the fruit thy body bore!

MEDEA

Yes: if the man I hate be pained the more.

LEADER

And thou made miserable, most miserable?

MEDEA

Oh, let it come! All words of good or ill
Are wasted now.

[She claps her hands: the Nurse comes out⁷² from the house.]

Ho, woman; get thee gone
And lead lord Jason hither. . . . There is none
Like thee, to work me these high services.
But speak no word of what my purpose is,
As thou art faithful, thou, and bold to try
All succours, and a woman even as I!⁷³

[*The Nurse departs.*]

CHORUS

The sons of Erechtheus, the olden,⁷⁴
Whom high gods planted of yore
In an old land of heaven upholden,
A proud land untrodden of war:
They are hungered, and, lo, their desire
With wisdom is fed as with meat:
In their skies is a shining of fire,
A joy in the fall of their feet:
And thither, with manifold dowers,
From the North, from the hills, from the morn,
The Muses did gather their powers,
That a child of the Nine should be born;
And Harmony, sown as the flowers,
Grew gold in the acres of corn.
And Cephîsus, the fair-flowing river—
The Cyprian dipping her hand
Hath drawn of his dew, and the shiver
Of her touch is as joy in the land.
For her breathing in fragrance is written,
And in music her path as she goes,
And the cloud of her hair, it is litten
With stars of the wind-woven rose.
So fareth she ever and ever,
And forth of her bosom is blown,
As dews on the winds of the river,
An hunger of passions unknown.
Strong Loves of all godlike endeavour,

Whom Wisdom shall throne on her throne.

Some Women.

But Cephîsus the fair-flowing,

Will he bear thee on his shore?

Shall the land that succours all, succour thee,

Who art foul among thy kind,

With the tears of children blind?

Dost thou see the red gash growing,

Thine own burden dost thou see?

Every side, Every way,

Lo, we kneel to thee and pray:

By thy knees, by thy soul, O woman wild!

One at least thou canst not slay,

Not thy child!

Others.

Hast thou ice that thou shalt bind it

To thy breast, and make thee dead

To thy children, to thine own spirit's pain?

When the hand knows what it dares,

When thine eyes look into theirs,

Shalt thou keep by tears unblinded

Thy dividing of the slain?

These be deeds Not for thee:

These be things that cannot be!

Thy babes—though thine hardihood be fell,

When they cling about thy knee,

‘Twill be well!

*Enter Jason.*⁷⁵

JASON

I answer to thy call. Though full of hate
Thou be, I yet will not so far abate
My kindness for thee, nor refuse mine ear.
Say in what new desire thou hast called me here.

MEDEA

Jason, I pray thee, for my words but now
Spoken, forgive me. My bad moods. . . . Oh, thou
At least wilt strive to bear with them! There be
Many old deeds of love 'twixt me and thee.
Lo, I have reasoned with myself apart
And chidden: "Why must I be mad, O heart
Of mine: and raging against one whose word
Is wisdom: making me a thing abhorred
To them that rule the land, and to mine own
Husband, who doth but that which, being done,
Will help us all—to wed a queen, and get
Young kings for brethren to my sons? And yet
I rage alone, and cannot quit my rage—
What aileth me?—when God sends harbourage
So simple? Have I not my children? Know
I not we are but exiles, and must go
Beggared and friendless else?" Thought upon thought
So pressed me, till I knew myself full-fraught
With bitterness of heart and blinded eyes.
So now—I give thee thanks: and hold thee wise
To have caught this anchor for our aid. The fool
Was I; who should have been thy friend, thy tool;
Gone wooing with thee, stood at thy bed-side
Serving, and welcomed duteously thy bride.

But, as we are, we are—I will not say

Mere evil—women! Why must thou to-day

Turn strange, and make thee like some evil thing,

Childish, to meet my childish passioning?

See, I surrender: and confess that then

I had bad thoughts, but now have turned again

And found my wiser mind. [*She claps her hands.*]

Ho, children! Run

Quickly! Come hither, out into the sun,

[*The Children come from the house, followed by their Attendant.*]

And greet your father. Welcome him with us,

And throw quite, quite away, as mother does,

Your anger against one so dear. Our peace

Is made, and all the old bad war shall cease

For ever.—Go, and take his hand. . . .

[*As the Children go to Jason, she suddenly bursts into tears. The Children quickly return to her: she recovers herself, smiling amid her tears.*]

Ah me,

I am full of hidden horrors! . . . Shall it be

A long time more, my children, that ye live

To reach to me those dear, dear arms? . . . Forgive!

I am so ready with my tears to-day,

And full of dread. . . . I sought to smooth away

The long strife with your father, and, lo, now

I have all drowned with tears this little brow!

[*She wipes the child's face.*]

LEADER

O'er mine eyes too there stealeth a pale tear:

Let the evil rest, O God, let it rest here!

JASON

Woman, indeed I praise thee now, nor say
Ill of thine other hour. 'Tis nature's way,
A woman needs must stir herself to wrath,
When work of marriage by so strange a path
Crosseth her lord. But thou, thine heart doth wend
The happier road. Thou hast seen, ere quite the end,
What choice must needs be stronger: which to do
Shows a wise-minded woman. . . . And for you,
Children; your father never has forgot
Your needs. If God but help him, he hath wrought
A strong deliverance for your weakness. Yea,
I think you, with your brethren, yet one day
Shall be the mightiest voices in this land.
Do you grow tall and strong. Your father's hand
Guideth all else, and whatso power divine
Hath alway helped him. . . . Ah, may it be mine
To see you yet in manhood, stern of brow,
Strong-armed, set high o'er those that hate me. . . .
How?

Woman, thy face is turned. Thy cheek is swept
With pallor of strange tears. Dost not accept
Gladly and of good will my benisons?

MEDEA

'Tis nothing. Thinking of these little ones. . . .

JASON

Take heart, then. I will guard them from all ill.

MEDEA

I do take heart. Thy word I never will
Mistrust. Alas, a woman's bosom bears

But woman's courage, a thing born for tears.

JASON

What ails thee?—All too sore thou weepest there.

MEDEA

I was their mother! When I heard thy prayer

Of long life for them, there swept over me

A horror, wondering how these things shall be.

But for the matter of my need that thou

Should speak with me, part I have said, and now

Will finish.—Seeing it is the king's behest

To cast me out from Corinth . . . aye, and best,

Far best, for me—I know it—not to stay

Longer to trouble thee and those who sway

The realm, being held to all their house a foe. . . .

Behold, I spread my sails, and meekly go

To exile. But our children. . . . Could this land

Be still their home awhile: could thine own hand

But guide their boyhood. . . . Seek the king, and pray

His pity, that he bid thy children stay!

JASON

He is hard to move. Yet surely 'twere well done.

MEDEA

Bid her—for thy sake, for a daughters boon. . . .

JASON

Well thought! Her I can fashion to my mind.

MEDEA

Surely. She is a woman like her kind. . . .

Yet I will aid thee in thy labour; I

Will send her gifts, the fairest gifts that lie

In the hands of men, things of the days of old,
Fine robings and a carcanet of gold,⁷⁶
By the boys' hands.—Go, quick, some handmaiden,
And fetch the raiment.

[A handmaid goes into the house.]

Ah, her cup shall then
Be filled indeed! What more should woman crave,
Being wed with thee, the bravest of the brave,
And girt with raiment which of old the sire
Of all my house, the Sun, gave, steeped in fire,
To his own fiery race?

[The handmaid has returned bearing the Gifts.]

Come, children, lift
With heed these caskets. Bear them as your gift
To her, being bride and princess and of right
Blessed!—I think she will not hold them light.

JASON

Fond woman, why wilt empty thus thine hand
Of treasure? Doth King Creon's castle stand
In stint of raiment, or in stint of gold?
Keep these, and make no gift. For if she hold
Jason of any worth at all, I swear
Chattels like these will not weigh more with her.

MEDEA

Ah, chide me not! 'Tis written, gifts persuade
The gods in heaven; and gold is stronger made
Than words innumerable to bend men's ways.
Fortune is hers. God maketh great her days:
Young and a crownèd queen! And banishment

For those two babes. . . I would not gold were spent,

But life's blood, ere that come.

My children, go

Forth into those rich halls, and, bowing low,

Beseech your father's bride, whom I obey,

Ye be not, of her mercy, cast away

Exiled: and give the caskets—above all

Mark this!—to none but her, to hold withal

And keep. . . Go quick! And let your mother know

Soon the good tiding that she longs for. . . Go!

[*She goes quickly into the house. Jason and the Children with their Attendant depart.*]

CHORUS

Now I have no hope more of the children's living;

No hope more. They are gone forth unto death.

The bride, she taketh the poison of their giving:

She taketh the bounden gold and openeth;

And the crown, the crown, she lifteth about her brow,

Where the light brown curls are clustering. No hope now!

O sweet and cloudy gleam of the garments golden!

The robe, it hath clasped her breast and the crown her head.

Then, then, she decketh the bride, as a bride of olden

Story, that goeth pale to the kiss of the dead.

For the ring hath closed, and the portion of death is there;

And she flieth not, but perisheth unaware.

Some Women.

O bridegroom, bridegroom of the kiss so cold,

Art thou wed with princes, art thou girt with gold,

Who know'st not, suing

For thy child's undoing,

And, on her thou lovest, for a doom untold?

How art thou fallen from thy place of old!

Others.

O Mother, Mother, what hast thou to reap,

When the harvest cometh, between wake and sleep?

For a heart unslaken,

For a troth forsaken,

Lo, babes that call thee from a bloody deep:

And thy love returns not. Get thee forth and weep!

Enter the Attendant with the two Children: Medea comes out from the house.

ATTENDANT

Mistress, these children from their banishment

Are spared. The royal bride hath mildly bent

Her hand to accept thy gifts, and all is now

Peace for the children.—Ha, why standest thou

Confounded, when good fortune draweth near?

MEDEA

Ah God!

ATTENDANT

This chimes not with the news I bear.

MEDEA

O God, have mercy!

ATTENDANT

Is some word of wrath

Here hidden that I knew not of? And hath

My hope to give thee joy so cheated me?

MEDEA

Thou givest what thou givest: I blame not thee.

ATTENDANT

Thy brows are all o'ercast: thine eyes are filled. . . .

MEDEA

For bitter need, Old Man! The gods have willed,
And my own evil mind, that this should come.

ATTENDANT

Take heart! Thy sons one day will bring thee home.

MEDEA

Home? . . . I have others to send home. Woe's me!

ATTENDANT

Be patient. Many a mother before thee
Hath parted from her children. We poor things
Of men must needs endure what fortune brings.

MEDEA

I will endure.—Go thou within, and lay
All ready that my sons may need to-day.

[*The Attendant goes into the house.*]

O children, children mine: and you have found
A land and home, where, leaving me discrowned
And desolate, forever you will stay,
Motherless children! And I go my way
To other lands, an exile, ere you bring
Your fruits home, ere I see you prospering
Or know your brides, or deck the bridal bed,
All flowers, and lift your torches overhead.
Oh cursèd be mine own hard heart! 'Twas all
In vain, then, that I reared you up, so tall
And fair; in vain I bore you, and was torn
With those long pitiless pains, when you were born.
Ah, wondrous hopes my poor heart had in you,

How you would tend me in mine age, and do
The shroud about me with your own dear hands,
When I lay cold, blessèd in all the lands
That knew us. And that gentle thought is dead!
You go, and I live on, to eat the bread
Of long years, to myself most full of pain.
And never your dear eyes, never again,
Shall see your mother, far away being thrown
To other shapes of life. . . . My babes, my own,
Why gaze ye so?—What is it that ye see?—
And laugh with that last laughter? . . . Woe is me,
What shall I do?
Women, my strength is gone,
Gone like a dream, since once I looked upon
Those shining faces. . . . I can do it not.
Good-bye to all the thoughts that burned so hot
Aforetime! I will take and hide them far,
Far, from men's eyes. Why should I seek a war
So blind: by these babes' wounds to sting again
Their father's heart, and win myself a pain
Twice deeper? Never, never! I forget
Henceforward all I laboured for.
And yet,
What is it with me? Would I be a thing
Mocked at, and leave mine enemies to sting
Unsmitten? It must be. O coward heart,
Ever to harbour such soft words!—Depart
Out of my sight, ye twain. [*The Children go in.*]
And they whose eyes

Shall hold it sin to share my sacrifice,
On their heads be it! My hand shall swerve not now.
Ah, Ah, thou Wrath within me! Do not thou,
Do not. . . . Down, down, thou tortured thing, and spare
My children! They will dwell with us, aye, there
Far off, and give thee peace.
Too late, too late!

By all Hell's living agonies of hate,
They shall not take my little ones alive
To make their mock with! Howsoever I strive
The thing is doomed; it shall not escape now
From being. Aye, the crown is on the brow,
And the robe girt, and in the robe that high
Queen dying.

I know all. Yet . . . seeing that I
Must go so long a journey, and these twain
A longer yet and darker, I would fain
Speak with them, ere I go.

[A handmaid brings the Children out again.]

Come, children; stand
A little from me. There. Reach out your hand,
Your right hand—so—to mother: and good-bye!

[She has kept them hitherto at arm's length: but at the touch of their hands, her resolution breaks down, and she gathers them passionately into her arms.]

Oh, darling hand! Oh, darling mouth, and eye,
And royal mien, and bright brave faces clear,
May you be blessèd, but not here! What here
Was yours, your father stole. . . . Ah God, the glow
Of cheek on cheek, the tender touch; and Oh,
Sweet scent of childhood. . . . Go! Go! . . . Am I blind? . . .

Mine eyes can see not, when I look to find

Their places. I am broken by the wings

Of evil. . . . Yea, I know to what bad things

I go, but louder than all thought doth cry

Anger, which maketh man's worst misery.

[*She follows the Children into the house.*]

CHORUS

My thoughts have roamed a cloudy land,

And heard a fierier music fall

Than woman's heart should stir withal:

And yet some Muse majestic,

Unknown, hath hold of woman's hand,

Seeking for Wisdom—not in all:

A feeble seed, a scattered band,

Thou yet shalt find in lonely places,

Not dead amongst us, nor our faces

Turned alway from the Muses' call.

And thus my thought would speak: that she

Who ne'er hath borne a child nor known

Is nearer to felicity:

Unlit she goeth and alone,

With little understanding what

A child's touch means of joy or woe,

And many toils she beareth not.

But they within whose garden fair

That gentle plant hath blown, they go

Deep-written all their days with care—

To rear the children, to make fast

Their hold, to win them wealth; and then

Much darkness, if the seed at last
Bear fruit in good or evil men!
And one thing at the end of all
Abideth, that which all men dread:
The wealth is won, the limbs are bred
To manhood, and the heart withal
Honest: and, lo, where Fortune smiled,
Some change, and what hath fallen? Hark!
‘Tis death slow winging to the dark,
And in his arms what was thy child.
What therefore doth it bring of gain
To man, whose cup stood full before,
That God should send this one thing more
Of hunger and of dread, a door
Set wide to every wind of pain?

[Medea comes out alone from the house.]

MEDEA

Friends, this long hour I wait on Fortune’s eyes,
And strain my senses in a hot surmise
What passeth on that hill.—Ha! even now
There comes . . . ‘tis one of Jason’s men, I trow.
His wild-perturbèd breath doth warrant me
The tidings of some strange calamity.

[Enter Messenger.]

MESSENGER

O dire and ghastly deed! Get thee away,
Medea! Fly! Nor let behind thee stay
One chariot’s wing, one keel that sweeps the seas. . . .

MEDEA

And what hath chanced, to cause such flights as these?

MESSENGER

The maiden princess lieth—and her sire,
The king—both murdered by thy poison-fire.

MEDEA

Most happy tiding! Which thy name prefers
Henceforth among my friends and well-wishers.

MESSENGER

What say'st thou? Woman, is thy mind within
Clear, and not raving? Thou art found in sin
Most bloody wrought against the king's high head,
And laughest at the tale, and hast no dread?

MEDEA

I have words also that could answer well
Thy word. But take thine ease, good friend, and tell,
How died they? Hath it been a very foul
Death, prithee? That were comfort to my soul.

MESSENGER

When thy two children, hand in hand entwined,
Came with their father, and passed on to find
The new-made bridal rooms, Oh, we were glad,
We thralls, who ever loved thee well, and had
Grief in thy grief. And straight there passed a word
From ear to ear, that thou and thy false lord
Had poured peace offering upon wrath foregone.
A right glad welcome gave we them, and one
Kissed the small hand, and one the shining hair:
Myself, for very joy, I followed where
The women's rooms are. There our mistress . . . she

Whom now we name so . . . thinking not to see
Thy little pair, with glad and eager brow
Sate waiting Jason. Then she saw, and slow
Shrouded her eyes, and backward turned again,
Sick that thy children should come near her. Then
Thy husband quick went forward, to entreat
The young maid's fitful wrath. "Thou wilt not meet
Love's coming with unkindness? Nay, refrain
Thy suddenness, and turn thy face again,
Holding as friends all that to me are dear,
Thine husband. And accept these robes they bear
As gifts: and beg thy father to unmake
His doom of exile on them—for my sake."
When once she saw the raiment, she could still
Her joy no more, but gave him all his will.
And almost ere the father and the two
Children were gone from out the room, she drew
The flowerèd garments forth, and sate her down
To her arraying: bound the golden crown
Through her long curls, and in a mirror fair
Arranged their separate clusters, smiling there
At the dead self that faced her. Then aside
She pushed her seat, and paced those chambers wide
Alone, her white foot poising delicately—
So passing joyful in those gifts was she!—
And many a time would pause, straight-limbed, and wheel
Her head to watch the long fold to her heel
Sweeping. And then came something strange. Her cheek
Seemed pale, and back with crooked steps and weak

Groping of arms she walked, and scarcely found
Her old seat, that she fell not to the ground.
Among the handmaids was a woman old
And grey, who deemed, I think, that Pan had hold
Upon her, or some spirit, and raised a keen
Awakening shout; till through her lips was seen
A white foam crawling, and her eyeballs back
Twisted, and all her face dead pale for lack
Of life: and while that old dame called, the cry
Turned strangely to its opposite, to die
Sobbing. Oh, swiftly then one woman flew
To seek her father's rooms, one for the new
Bridegroom, to tell the tale. And all the place
Was loud with hurrying feet.
So long a space
As a swift walker on a measured way
Would pace a furlong's course in, there she lay
Speechless, with veiled lids. Then wide her eyes
She oped, and wildly, as she strove to rise,
Shrieked: for two diverse waves upon her rolled
Of stabbing death. The carcanet of gold
That gripped her brow was molten in a dire
And wondrous river of devouring fire.
And those fine robes, the gift thy children gave—
God's mercy!—everywhere did lap and lave
The delicate flesh; till up she sprang, and fled,
A fiery pillar, shaking locks and head
This way and that, seeking to cast the crown
Somewhere away. But like a thing nailed down

The burning gold held fast the anadem,
And through her locks, the more she scattered them,
Came fire the fiercer, till to earth she fell
A thing—save to her sire—scarce nameable,
And strove no more. That cheek of royal mien,
Where was it—or the place where eyes had been?
Only from crown and temples came faint blood
Shot through with fire. The very flesh, it stood
Out from the bones, as from a wounded pine
The gum starts, where those gnawing poisons fine
Bit in the dark—a ghastly sight! And touch
The dead we durst not. We had seen too much.
But that poor father, knowing not, had sped,
Swift to his daughter's room, and there the dead
Lay at his feet. He knelt, and groaning low,
Folded her in his arms, and kissed her: "Oh,
Unhappy child, what thing unnatural hath
So hideously undone thee? Or what wrath
Of gods, to make this old grey sepulchre
Childless of thee? Would God but lay me there
To die with thee, my daughter!" So he cried.
But after, when he stayed from tears, and tried
To uplift his old bent frame, lo, in the folds
Of those fine robes it held, as ivy holds
Strangling among your laurel boughs. Oh, then
A ghastly struggle came! Again, again,
Up on his knee he writhed; but that dead breast
Clung still to his: till, wild, like one possessed,
He dragged himself half free; and, lo, the live

Flesh parted; and he laid him down to strive
No more with death, but perish; for the deep
Had risen above his soul. And there they sleep,
At last, the old proud father and the bride,
Even as his tears had craved it, side by side.
For thee—Oh, no word more! Thyself will know
How best to baffle vengeance. . . . Long ago
I looked upon man's days, and found a grey
Shadow. And this thing more I surely say,
That those of all men who are counted wise,
Strong wits, devisers of great policies,
Do pay the bitterest toll. Since life began,
Hath there in God's eye stood one happy man?
Fair days roll on, and bear more gifts or less
Of fortune, but to no man happiness.

[*Exit Messenger.*]

CHORUS

Some Women.

Wrath upon wrath, meseems, this day shall fall
From God on Jason! He hath earned it all.

Other Women.

O miserable maiden, all my heart
Is torn for thee, so sudden to depart
From thy king's chambers and the light above
To darkness, all for sake of Jason's love!

MEDEA

Women, my mind is clear. I go to slay
My children with all speed, and then, away
From hence; not wait yet longer till they stand

Beneath another and an angrier hand
To die. Yea, howsoe'er I shield them, die
They must. And, seeing that they must, 'tis I
Shall slay them, I their mother, touched of none
Beside. Oh, up and get thine armour on,
My heart! Why longer tarry we to win
Our crown of dire inevitable sin?
Take up thy sword, O poor right hand of mine,
Thy sword: then onward to the thin-drawn line
Where life turns agony. Let there be naught
Of softness now: and keep thee from that thought,
'Born of thy flesh,' 'thine own belovèd.' Now,
For one brief day, forget thy children: thou
Shalt weep hereafter. Though thou slay them, yet
Sweet were they. . . . I am sore unfortunate.

[She goes into the house.]

CHORUS

Some Women.

O Earth, our mother; and thou
All-seër, arrowy crown
Of Sunlight, manward now
Look down, Oh, look down!
Look upon one accurst,
Ere yet in blood she twine
Red hands—blood that is thine!
O Sun, save her first!
She is thy daughter still,
Of thine own golden line;
Save her! Or shall man spill

The life divine?

Give peace, O Fire that diest not! Send thy spell

To stay her yet, to lift her afar, afar—

A torture-changed spirit, a voice of Hell

Wrought of old wrongs and war!

Others.

Alas for the mother's pain

Wasted! Alas the dear

Life that was born in vain!

Woman, what mak'st thou here,

Thou from beyond the Gate

Where dim Symplêgades

Clash in the dark blue seas,

The shores where death doth wait?

Why hast thou taken on thee,

To make us desolate,

This anger of misery

And guilt of hate?

For fierce are the smittings back of blood once shed

Where love hath been: God's wrath upon them that kill,

And an anguished earth, and the wonder of the dead

Haunting as music still. . . .

[*A cry is heard within.*]

A WOMAN

Hark! Did ye hear? Heard ye the children's cry?

ANOTHER

O miserable woman! O abhorred!

A CHILD WITHIN

What shall I do? What is it? Keep me fast

From mother!

THE OTHER CHILD

I know nothing. Brother! Oh,

I think she means to kill us.

A WOMAN

Let me go!

I will—Help! Help!—and save them at the last.

A CHILD

Yes, in God's name! Help quickly ere we die!

THE OTHER CHILD

She has almost caught me now. She has a sword.

[Many of the Women are now beating at the barred door to get in. Others are standing apart.

Women at the door.]

Thou stone, thou thing of iron! Wilt verily

Spill with thine hand that life, the vintage stored

Of thine own agony?

The Other Women.

A Mother slew her babes in days of yore,

One, only one, from dawn to eventide,

Ino, god-maddened, whom the Queen of Heaven

Set frenzied, flying to the dark: and she

Cast her for sorrow to the wide salt sea,

Forth from those rooms of murder unforgiven,

Wild-footed from a white crag of the shore,

And clasping still her children twain, she died.

O Love of Woman, charged with sorrow sore,

What hast thou wrought upon us? What beside

Resteth to tremble for?

[Enter hurriedly Jason and Attendants.

JASON

Ye women by this doorway clustering
Speak, is the doer of the ghastly thing
Yet here, or fled? What hopeth she of flight?
Shall the deep yawn to shield her? Shall the height
Send wings, and hide her in the vaulted sky
To work red murder on her lords, and fly
Unrecompensed? But let her go! My care
Is but to save my children, not for her.
Let them she wronged requite her as they may.
I care not. 'Tis my sons I must some way
Save, ere the kinsmen of the dead can win
From them the payment of their mother's sin.

LEADER

Unhappy man, indeed thou knowest not
What dark place thou art come to! Else, God wot,
Jason, no word like these could fall from thee.

JASON

What is it?—Ha! The woman would kill me?

LEADER

Thy sons are dead, slain by their mother's hand.

JASON

How? Not the children. . . . I scarce understand. . . .

O God, thou hast broken me!

LEADER

Think of those twain
As things once fair, that ne'er shall bloom again.

JASON

Where did she murder them? In that old room?

LEADER

Open, and thou shalt see thy children's doom.

JASON

Ho, thralls! Unloose me yonder bars! Make more

Of speed! Wrench out the jointing of the door.

And show my two-edged curse, the children dead,

The woman. . . . Oh, this sword upon her head. . . .

[While the Attendants are still battering at the door Medea appears on the roof, standing on a chariot of winged Dragons, in which are the children's bodies.]

MEDEA

What make ye at my gates? Why batter ye

With brazen bars, seeking the dead and me

Who slew them? Peace! . . . And thou, if aught of mine

Thou needest, speak, though never touch of thine

Shall scathe me more. Out of his firmament

My fathers' father, the high Sun, hath sent

This, that shall save me from mine enemies' rage.

JASON

Thou living hate! Thou wife in every age

Abhorred, blood-red mother, who didst kill

My sons, and make me as the dead: and still

Canst take the sunshine to thine eyes, and smell

The green earth, reeking from thy deed of hell;

I curse thee! Now, Oh, now mine eyes can see,

That then were blinded, when from savagery

Of eastern chambers, from a cruel land,

To Greece and home I gathered in mine hand

Thee, thou incarnate curse: one that betrayed

Her home, her father, her . . . Oh, God hath laid

Thy sins on me!—I knew, I knew, there lay

A brother murdered on thy hearth that day

When thy first footstep fell on Argo's hull. . . .

Argo, my own, my swift and beautiful

That was her first beginning. Then a wife

I made her in my house. She bore to life

Children: and now for love, for chambering

And men's arms, she hath murdered them! A thing

Not one of all the maids of Greece, not one,

Had dreamed of; whom I spurned, and for mine own

Chose thee, a bride of hate to me and death,

Tigress, not woman, beast of wilder breath

Than Skylla shrieking o'er the Tuscan sea.

Enough! No scorn of mine can reach to thee,

Such iron is o'er thine eyes. Out from my road,

Thou crime-begetter, blind with children's blood!

And let me weep alone the bitter tide

That sweepeth Jason's days, no gentle bride

To speak with more, no child to look upon

Whom once I reared . . . all, all for ever gone!

MEDEA

An easy answer had I to this swell

Of speech, but Zeus our father knoweth well,

All I for thee have wrought, and thou for me.

So let it rest. This thing was not to be,

That thou shouldst live a merry life, my bed

Forgotten and my heart uncomforted,

Thou nor thy princess: nor the king that planned

Thy marriage drive Medea from his land,

And suffer not. Call me what thing thou please,

Tigress or Skylla from the Tuscan seas:

My claws have gripped thine heart, and all things shine.

JASON

Thou too hast grief. Thy pain is fierce as mine.

MEDEA

I love the pain, so thou shalt laugh no more.

JASON

Oh, what a womb of sin my children bore!

MEDEA

Sons, did ye perish for your father's shame?

JASON

How? It was not my hand that murdered them.

MEDEA

'Twas thy false wooings, 'twas thy trampling pride.

JASON

Thou hast said it! For thy lust of love they died.

MEDEA

And love to women a slight thing should be?

JASON

To women pure!—All thy vile life to thee!

MEDEA

Think of thy torment. They are dead, they are dead!

JASON

No: quick, great God; quick curses round thy head!

MEDEA

The Gods know who began this work of woe.

JASON

Thy heart and all its loathliness they know.

MEDEA

Loathe on. . . But, Oh, thy voice. It hurts me sore.

JASON

Aye, and thine me. Wouldst hear me then no more?

MEDEA

How? Show me but the way. 'Tis this I crave.

JASON

Give me the dead to weep, and make their grave.

MEDEA

Never! Myself will lay them in a still

Green sepulchre, where Hera by the Hill

Hath precinct holy, that no angry men

May break their graves and cast them forth again

To evil. So I lay on all this shore

Of Corinth a high feast for evermore

And rite, to purge them yearly of the stain

Of this poor blood. And I, to Pallas' plain

I go, to dwell beside Pandion's son,

Aegeus.—For thee, behold, death draweth on,

Evil and lonely, like thine heart: the hands

Of thine old Argo, rotting where she stands,

Shall smite thine head in twain, and bitter be

To the last end thy memories of me.

[She rises on the chariot and is slowly borne away.]

JASON

May They that hear the weeping child

Blast thee, and They that walk in blood!

MEDEA

Thy broken vows, thy friends beguiled

Have shut for thee the ears of God.

JASON

Go, thou art wet with children's tears!

MEDEA

Go thou, and lay thy bride to sleep.

JASON

Childless, I go, to weep and weep.

MEDEA

Not yet! Age cometh and long years.

JASON

My sons, mine own!

MEDEA

Not thine, but mine . . .

JASON

. . . Who slew them!

MEDEA

Yes: to torture thee.

JASON

Once let me kiss their lips, once twine

Mine arms and touch. . . Ah, woe is me!

MEDEA

Wouldst love them and entreat? But now

They were as nothing.

JASON

At the last,

O God, to touch that tender brow!

MEDEA

Thy words upon the wind are cast.

JASON

Thou, Zeus, wilt hear me. All is said

For naught. I am but spurned away
And trampled by this tigress, red
With children's blood. Yet, come what may,
So far as thou hast granted, yea,
So far as yet my strength may stand,
I weep upon these dead, and say
Their last farewell, and raise my hand
To all the daemons of the air
In witness of these things; how she
Who slew them, will not suffer me
To gather up my babes, nor bear
To earth their bodies; whom, O stone
Of women, would I ne'er had known
Nor gotten, to be slain by thee!
[He casts himself upon the earth.]

CHORUS

Great treasure halls hath Zeus in heaven,
From whence to man strange dooms be given,
Past hope or fear.
And the end men looked for cometh not,
And a path is there where no man thought:
So hath it fallen here.

OEDIPUS THE KING

Sophocles (ca. 496-ca. 406 B.C.E.)

Composed ca. 429-420 B.C.E. Greece

Although Sophocles wrote over one hundred plays, only seven survive. In competitions during religious festivals for Dionysus, which required three playwrights to present three dramatic plays each (plus a farce), Sophocles won first place at least twenty times; the rest of the time, he came in second (never third). Greek plays previously had a chorus and one actor on stage; Aeschylus (ca. 525-456) introduced the idea of a second actor, while Sophocles was the first to have three actors, plus painted scenery as a backdrop for the action. Masks allowed the (all male) actors to portray men, women, children, and gods

without confusion. Since the stories were familiar to the audience, the popularity of Sophocles stems from his clever wordplay and insightful grasp of psychology. The three plays that cover the story of Oedipus and his family are referred to as the Theban cycle, although they were written for different competitions over 36 years of his career: *Antigone*, which was written first, but chronologically is the last story; *Oedipus Tyrannos* (or just *Oedipus*), which was written second, but chronologically is the first story; and *Oedipus at Colonus*, which was written last, but chronologically is the second story. *Oedipus* begins *in medias res*, with the city of Thebes suffering from a plague; as the king, Oedipus is trying to discover why the gods are punishing the city.

Written by Laura J. Getty



Image 1.10: Sophocles | A bust of Sophocles, currently housed at the Pushkin Museum.

Author: User “Shakko”

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1.6.1 Oedipus the King

Oedipus Tyrannus

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Sophocles, Translated by D. W. Myatt

Characters:

Oedipus, King of Thebes

Jocasta, his Consort and wife

Creon, brother of Jocasta

Tiresias, the blind prophet

A Priest, of Zeus

First Messenger Second Messenger A Shepherd

Chorus, of Theban Elders

Scene: Before the wealthy dwelling of Oedipus at Thebes

OEDIPUS

My children—you most recently reared from ancient Cadmus—

Why do you hasten to these seats

Wreathed in suppliant branches?

Since the citadel is filled with incense,

Chants and lamentations

I did not deem it fitting, my children, to hear

The report of some messenger—so I come here myself:

I, Oedipus the renowned, who is respected by you all.

As you, Elder, are distinguished by nature,

You should speak for these others. Is your manner

One of fear or affection? My will is to assist you

For I would be indifferent to pain

Were I not to have pity after such a supplication as this.

PRIEST

Oedipus, master of my land:

You see how many sit here

Before your altars—some not yet robust enough

To fly far; some heavy as I, Priest of Zeus, with age;

And these, chosen from our unmarried youth.

Enwreathed like them, our people sit in the place of markets,

By the twin shrines of Pallas

And by the embers of the Ismenian oracle.

Our clan, as you yourself behold, already heaves

Too much—its head bent

To the depths bloodily heaving.

Decay is in the unfruitful seeds in the soil,

Decay is in our herds of cattle—our women

Are barren or abort, and that god of fever

Swoops down to strike our clan with an odious plague,

Emptying the abode of Cadmus and giving dark Hades

An abundance of wailing and lamentation.

Not as an equal of the gods do I,

And these children who sit by your altar, behold you—

But as the prime man in our problems of life

And in our dealings and agreements with daimons.

You arrived at our town of Cadmus to disentangle us

From the tax we paid to that harsh Songstress—

And that with less than we knew because

Without our experience. Rather—and it is the custom

To say this—you had the support of a god

And so made our lives to prosper.

Thus, Oedipus—you, the most noble of all—

We all as suppliants beseech you

To find us a defence, whether it be from a god's oracle

Or whether it be learnt from some man.

For those who are practical are, by events,

Seen to give counsels which are the most effective.

Most noble among mortals—restore our clan!

But—be cautious. For now this land of yours

Names you their protector for your swiftness before—

Do not let it be recorded of your leadership

That you raised us up again only to let us thereafter fall:

So make us safe, and restore our clan.

Favourable—then—the omens, and prosperity

You brought us: be of the same kind, again!

For, in commanding a land, as you are master of this,

It is much better to be master of men than of an emptiness!

Of no value are a ship or a defensive tower

If they are empty because no men dwell within them.

OEDIPUS

You, my children, who lament—I know, for I am not without knowledge,

Of the desire which brings you here. For well do I see

All your sufferings—and though you suffer, it is I

And not one of you that suffers the most.

For your pain comes to each of you

By itself, with nothing else, while my psyche

Mourns for myself, for you and the clan.

You have not awakened me from a resting sleep

For indeed you should know of my many tears

And the many paths of reflection I have wandered upon and tried.

And, as I pondered, I found one cure

Which I therefore took. The son of Menoeceus,

Creon—he who is my kin by marriage—I have sent to that Pythian dwelling

Of Phoebus to learn how I

By word or deed can give deliverance to the clan.

But I have already measured the duration

And am concerned: for where is he? He is longer than expected

For his absence is, in duration, greater than is necessary.

Yet when he does arrive, it would dishonourable

For me not to act upon all that the gods makes clear.

PRIEST

It is fitting that you spoke thus—for observe that now

We are signalled that Creon is approaching.

OEDIPUS

Lord Apollo! Let our fate be such

That we are saved—and as bright as his face now is!

PRIEST

I conjecture it is pleasing since he arrives with his head crowned

By laurel wreaths bearing many berries.

OEDIPUS

Soon we will know, for, in distance, he can hear us now.

[Enter Creon]

Lord—son of Menoeceus—my kin by marriage:

Give to us the saying you received from the god!

CREON

It is propitious, for I call it fortunate when what is difficult to bear

Is taken from us, enabling us thus to prosper again.

OEDIPUS

But what is it? I am not given more courage

Nor more fear by your words.

CREON

Do you insist upon hearing it here,

Within reach of these others—or shall we go within?

OEDIPUS

Speak it to all. For my concern for their suffering

Is more than even that for my own psyche.

CREON

Then I shall speak to you what I heard from the god.

The command of Lord Phoebus was clear—

That defilement nourished by our soil

Must be driven away, not given nourishment until it cannot be cured.

OEDIPUS

When came this misfortune? How to be cleansed?

CREON

Banishment of a man—or a killing in return for the killing

To release us from the blood and thus this tempest upon our clan.

OEDIPUS

What man is thus fated to be so denounced?

CREON

My Lord, Laius was the Chief

Of this land, before you guided us.

OEDIPUS

That I have heard and know well although I never saw him.

CREON

Because he was slaughtered it is clearly ordered that you

Must punish the killing hands, whosoever they are.

OEDIPUS

But are they in this land? Can we still find

The now faded marks of the ancient tracks of those so accused?

CREON

Still in our land, he said. What is sought

Can be caught, but will escape if not attended to.

OEDIPUS

Was Laius in his dwelling, in his fields,

Or in another land when he met his death?

CREON

He said he was journeying to a shrine:

But, having gone, he did not return.

OEDIPUS

Was there no messenger, no other with him

Who saw anything and whom we could consult and thus learn from?

CREON

No—killed: all of them. Except one who fled in fear

And so saw nothing except the one thing he did speak of seeing.

OEDIPUS

What? One thing may help us learn many more

And such a small beginning may bring us hope.

CREON

He announced that robbers came upon them and, there being so many,

In their strength slew them with their many hands.

OEDIPUS

How could robbers do that? Unless—unless silver

Was paid to them, from here! Otherwise, they would not have the courage!

CREON

Such was the opinion. But with Laius killed

No one arose to be his avenger since we had other troubles.

OEDIPUS

What troubles were before you that with your King fallen

You were kept from looking?

CREON

The convoluted utterances of the Sphinx made us consider what was before us

And leave unknown what was dark.

OEDIPUS

Then, as a start, I shall go back to make it visible.

It is fitting for Phoebus, and fitting also for you

For the sake of him dead, to return your concern there

And fair that I am seen as an ally
In avenging this land and the god.
Yet not in the name of remote kin
But for myself will I banish the abomination
Since that person who killed may—and soon—
And by his own hand, wish to avenge me.
Thus in this way by so giving aid, I also benefit myself.
Now and swiftly, my children, stand up from these steps—
Raising your suppliant branches—
And go to summon here the people of Cadmus
For I shall do all that is required. Either good fortune—
If the gods wills—will be shown to be ours, or we shall perish.

[*Exit Oedipus*]

PRIEST

Stand, children, for that favour
For which we came he has announced he will do.
May Phoebus—who delivered this oracle—
Be our Saviour and cause our suffering to cease.

[*Exit Priest. Enter Chorus*]

CHORUS

Zeus—your pleasing voice has spoken
But in what manner from gold-rich Pytho do you come
To the splendour that is Thebes?
My reason is stretched by dread as fear shakes me—
O Delian Paeon I invoke you!—
And I am in awe. For is this new
Or the continuation of that obligation
Which each season brings again?
Speak to me with your divine voice,

You born from she whom we treasure—our Hope!

You I shall name first—you the daughter of Zeus, the divine Athene!

And then you, her sister, who defends our lands—Artemis!—

Whose illustrious throne is the circle of our market.

And you, Phoebus with your far-reaching arrows!

You—the triad who guard us from death! Appear to me!

When misfortune moved over our clan before

You came to completely drive away that injuring fire—

So now come to us, again!

Beyond count are the injuries I bear

And all my comrades are sick;

There is no spear of thought to defend us—

The offspring of our fertile soil do not grow

While at the birth there are no cries of joy

For the women stretched by their labour:

I behold one after another rushing forth—swifter than feathered birds,

Swifter than invincible fire—

Toward the land of the twilight god!

They are beyond count and make the clan to die:

For her descendants lie unpitied, unmourned on the ground

Condemning others to death

As both the child-less and the mothers gather

Around the base of the altars

To labour as suppliants with their injurious laments

Although clear are the hymns to the Healer

Above those accompanying wailing voices!

In answer, you whom we hold precious—daughter of Zeus—

Send us She of strength with the beautiful eyes!

Grant that fiery Ares—he who fights not with shield of bronze

But who burns as he encircles with his battle-cry—
Turns around to swiftly run back, away from our fatherland
With a fair wind following, to that great Chamber of Amphitrite
Or to that Thracian harbour where strangers are dashed,
Since what he neglects at night He achieves when day arrives.
Thus—you who carry fire,
Who bestows the power of lighting—
All-father Zeus: waste him beneath your thunder!
Lord Lyceus! From your gold-bound bowstring
I wish you to deal out the hardest of your arrows
So they rise before us as a defence!
And you—Artemis—who by your gleaming light
Rushes through the mountains of Lycia.
And you of the golden mitre whose name
Is that of our land—I invoke you
Ruddied Bacchus with E-U-O-I!—
With your roaming Maenads
Come near to us with your blazing pine-torch
And gleaming eyes, to be our ally
Against that god given no honour by gods!

[*Enter Oedipus*]

OEDIPUS

You ask and what you ask will come—
For if you in your sickness listen and accept and assist me
You shall receive the strength to lift you out of this trouble.
I here make the declaration even though I am a stranger to that report
And a stranger to that deed. I, myself, would not have delayed
Tracking this, even had there been no signs.
But since it was after these things I became a tax-paying citizen among you citizens,

I proclaim this now to all who are of Cadmus:
Whosoever, concerning Laius son of Labdacus,
Knows the man who killed him
I command him to declare everything to me.
But if he is afraid, he can himself remove the accusation
Against him since what awaits him
Shall not be hostile since he shall pass uninjured to another land.
But if you know of another from another region
Whose hand did it, do not be silent
For I shall reward and confer favours upon you.
But if you keep silent because he is your own kin
Or because you yourself are afraid and so reject this—
Then hear what I of necessity must do.
I forbid that man, whoever he is, to be in this land—
This land where I have power and authority:
No one is to receive him nor speak to him;
Neither is he to share in your offering thanks to the gods,
Nor in the sacrifices or in the libations before them.
Instead, everyone shall push him away—for our defilement
Is, in truth, him: as the Pythian god
By his oracle just now announced to me.
Thus in such a way do I and this god
And the man who was killed become allies—
And so this pact I make concerning he who did that deed
Whether alone or together with others in secret:
Being ignoble, may his miserable life ignobly waste away.
And I also make this pact—that should he arrive at my dwelling
And with my consent stay by my hearth, then may that disease
I desired for those ones come to me!

So I command you to accomplish this
On behalf of me, the god and this land
Now barren, lain waste and without gods.
For even had no god sent you to deal with this matter
It would not have been fitting to leave it uncleaned
For the man killed was both brave and your own lord:
You should have enquired. However, I now have the authority
And hold the command that was his,
And now possess his chambers and his woman—seeded by us both—
And by whom we might have children shared in common had that family
Not had its misfortune and thus there had been a birth:
But it was not to be, for fate bore down upon him.
Thus, I—as if he were my own father—
Will fight for him and will go to any place
To search for and to seize the one whose hand killed
That son of Labdacus—he of Polydorus,
Of Cadmus before that and before then of ancient Agenor.
As to those who do not do this for me, I ask the god
That the seeds they sow in the earth shall not bring forth shoots
Nor their women children, and also that it be their destiny
To be destroyed by this thing—or one that is much worse.
But as for you others, of Cadmus, to whom this is pleasing—
May the goddess, Judgement, who is on our side,
And all of the gods, be with us forever.

CHORUS

Bound by your oath, my Lord, I speak:
I am not the killer—nor can I point out he who did the killing.
It is he who sent us on this search—
Phoebus—who should say who did that work.

OEDIPUS

That would be fair. But to compel the gods

Against their will is not within the power of any man.

CHORUS

Shall I speak of what I consider is the second best thing to do?

OEDIPUS

Do not neglect to explain to me even what is third!

CHORUS

He who sees the most of what Lord Phoebus knows

Is Lord Tiresias—and it is from his watching, and clearness,

My Lord, that we might learn the most.

OEDIPUS

I have not been inactive in attending to that:

Since Creon spoke of it, I have sent two escorts—

And it is a wonder after this long why he is not here.

CHORUS

What can still be told of those things is blunt from age.

OEDIPUS

What is there? For I am watching for any report.

CHORUS

It was said that he was killed by travellers.

OEDIPUS

That I have heard—but no one sees here he who observed that.

CHORUS

But he will have had his share of fear

Having heard your pact—and will not have stayed here.

OEDIPUS

And he who had no fear of the deed? Would such a one fear such words?

CHORUS

But here is he who can identify him. For observe,

It is the prophet of the god who is led here:

He who of all mortals has the most ability to reveal things.

[Enter Tiresias, guided by a boy]

OEDIPUS

Tiresias—you who are learned in all things: what can be taught; what is never spoken of;

What is in the heavens and what treads on the earth—

Although you have no sight, can you see how our clan

Has given hospitality to sickness? You are our shield,

Our protector—for you, Lord, are the only remedy we have.

Phoebus—if you have not heard it from the messengers—

Sent us as answer to our sending: release from the sickness

Will come only if we are skilled enough to discover who killed Laius

And kill them or drive them away from this land as fugitives.

Therefore, do not deny to us from envy the speech of birds

Or any other way of divination which you have,

But pull yourself and this clan—and me—

Pull us away from all that is defiled by those who lie slain.

Our being depends on you. For if a man assists someone

When he has the strength to do so, then it is a noble labour.

TIRESIAS

Ah! There is harm in judging when there is no advantage

In such a judgement. This I usefully understood

But then totally lost. I should not have come here.

OEDIPUS

What is this? Are you heartless, entering here so?

TIRESIAS

Permit me to return to my dwelling. Easier then will it be

For you to carry what is yours, and I what is mine, if you are persuaded in this.

OEDIPUS

Such talk is unusual because unfriendly toward this clan

Which nourishes you: will you deprive us of oracles?

TIRESIAS

Yes—for I know that the words you say

Are not suitable. And I will not suffer because of mine.

OEDIPUS

Before the gods! Turn aside that judgement! Here, before you,

All of us are as humble suppliants!

TIRESIAS

Since all of you lack judgement, I will not speak either about myself

Or you and so tell about defects.

OEDIPUS

What? If you are aware of it but will not speak,

Do you intend to betray and so totally destroy your clan?

TIRESIAS

I will not cause pain to either you or myself. Therefore,

Why these aimless rebukes since I will not answer.

OEDIPUS

Not...? Why, you ignoble, worthless...! A rock,

By its nature, can cause anger. Speak it!—

Or will you show there is no end to your hardness?

TIRESIAS

You rebuke me for anger—but it is with you

That she dwells, although you do not see this and blame me instead.

OEDIPUS

And whose being would not have anger

Hearing how you dishonour our clan!

TIRESIAS

By themselves, these things will arrive—even though my silence covers them.

OEDIPUS

Then since they shall arrive, you must speak to me about them!

TIRESIAS

Beyond this, I explain nothing. But if it is your will,

Become savage with wrath in anger.

OEDIPUS

Yes indeed I will yield to the anger possessing me

Since I do understand! For I know you appear to me

To have worked together with others to produce that deed,

Although it was not your hand that did the killing. But—had you sight—

I would say that the blow was yours and yours alone!

TIRESIAS

Is that so! I declare it is to the proclamation

You announced that you must adhere to, so that from this day

You should not speak to me or these others

Since you are the unhealthy pollution in our soil!

OEDIPUS

It is disrespectful to bound forth

With such speech! Do you believe you will escape?

TIRESIAS

I have escaped. For, by my revelations, I am nourished and made strong.

OEDIPUS

Where was your instruction from? Certainly not from your craft!

TIRESIAS

From you—for against my desire I cast out those words.

OEDIPUS

What words? Say them again so I can fully understand.

TIRESIAS

Did you not hear them before? Or are your words a test?

OEDIPUS

They expressed no meaning to me. Say them again.

TIRESIAS

I said you are the killer and thus the man you seek.

OEDIPUS

You shall not escape if you injure me so again!

TIRESIAS

Shall I then say more to make your anger greater?

OEDIPUS

As much as you desire for you are mistaken in what you say.

TIRESIAS

I say that with those nearest to you are you concealed

In disrespectful intimacy, not seeing the trouble you are in.

OEDIPUS

Do you believe you can continue to speak so and remain healthy?

TIRESIAS

Yes, if revelations have power.

OEDIPUS

They do for others, but not for you! They have none for you

Because you are blind in your ears, in your purpose as well as in your eyes!

TIRESIAS

In faulting me for that you are unfortunate

Because soon there will be no one who does not find fault with you.

OEDIPUS

You are nourished by night alone! It is not for me,

Or anyone here who sees by the light, to injure you.

TIRESIAS

It is not my destiny to be defeated by you—

Apollo is sufficient for that, since it is his duty to obtain vengeance.

OEDIPUS

Were those things Creon's inventions—or yours?

TIRESIAS

It is not Creon who harms you—it is yourself.

OEDIPUS

Ah! Wealth, Kingship and that art of arts

Which surpasses others—these, in life, are envied:

And great is the jealousy cherished because of you.

It is because of this authority of mine—which this clan

Gave into my hands, unasked—

That the faithful Creon, a comrade from the beginning,

Desires to furtively creep about to overthrow me

And hires this performing wizard,

This cunning mendicant priest who sees only

For gain but who is blind in his art!

So now tell me: where and when have you given clear divinations?

For you did not—when that bitch was here chanting her verses—

Speak out and so give deliverance to your clansfolk.

Yet her enigma was not really for some passing man

To disclose since it required a prophet's art:

But your augury foretold nothing and neither did you learn anything

From any god! It was I who came along—

I, Oedipus, who sees nothing!—I who put an end to her

By happening to use reason rather than a knowledge of augury.

Now it is me you are trying to exile since your purpose

Is to stand beside the throne among Creon's supporters.

But I intend to make you sorry! Both of you—who worked together

To drive me out. And if I did not respect you as an Elder,

Pain would teach you a kind of judgement!

CHORUS

Yet I suspect that he has spoken

In anger, as I believe you did, Oedipus.

But this is not what is needed. Instead, it is the god's oracle

That will, if examined, give us the best remedy.

TIRESIAS

Though you are the King, I have at least an equality of words

In return, for I also have authority.

I do not live as your servant—but for Loxias—

Just as I am not inscribed on the roll as being under Creon's patronage.

Thus, I speak for myself—since you have found fault with me because I am blind.

When you look, you do not see the trouble you are in,

Nor where you dwell, nor who you are intimate with.

Do you know from whom your being arose? Though concealed, you are the enemy

Of your own, below and upon this land:

On both sides beaten by your mother and your father

To be driven out from this land by a swift and angry Fury—

And you who now see straight will then be in darkness.

What place will not be a haven for your cries?

What Cithaeron will not, and soon, resound with them

When you understand your wedding-night in that abode

Into where you fatefully and easily sailed but which is no haven from your voyage?

Nor do you understand the multitude of troubles

Which will make you equal with yourself and your children.

Thus it is, so therefore at my mouth and at Creon's

Throw your dirt! For there is no other mortal whose being

Will be so completely overwhelmed by troubles as yours.

OEDIPUS

Am I to endure hearing such things from him?

May misfortune come to you! Go from here—without delay!

Away from my dwelling! Turn and go!

TIRESIAS

I would not have come here, had you not invited me.

OEDIPUS

I did not know you would speak nonsense

Or I would have been unwilling to ask you here to my dwelling.

TIRESIAS

So you believe I was born lacking sense?

Yet I made sense to those who gave you birth.

OEDIPUS

What? Wait! Which mortals gave me birth?

TIRESIAS

It is on this day that you are born and also destroyed.

OEDIPUS

All that you have said is enigmatic or lacking in reason.

TIRESIAS

But are you not the best among us in working things out?

OEDIPUS

Do you find fault with what I have discovered is my strength?

TIRESIAS

It is that very fortune which has totally ruined you.

OEDIPUS

I am not concerned—if I have preserved this clan.

TIRESIAS

Then I shall depart. You—boy! Lead me away.

OEDIPUS

Let him lead you away. While here, you are under my feet

And annoy me. When gone—you will give me no more pain.

TIRESIAS

I shall go but speak that for which I was fetched, with no dread

Because of your countenance. For you cannot harm me.

I say that the man you have long searched for

And threatened and made proclamation about for the killing

Of Laius—he is present, here.

Although called a foreigner among us, he will be exposed as a native

Of Thebes but have no delight in that event.

Blind, though recently able to see—

And a beggar, who before was rich—he shall go to foreign lands

With a stick to guide him along the ground on his journey.

And he shall be exposed to his children as both their father

And their brother; to the woman who gave him birth

As both her son and husband; and to his father

As his killer who seeded her after him. So go

Within to reason this out and if you catch me deceiving you,

Then say that in my prophecies there is nothing for me to be proud of.

[*Exit Tiresias and Oedipus*]

CHORUS

Who is the one that the god-inspired oracle-stone at Delphi saw

With bloody hands doing that which it is forbidden to speak of?

For now is the day for him to move his feet swifter

Than storm's horses as he flees

Since the son of Zeus—armed with fire and lightning—

Is leaping toward him

Accompanied by those angry

And infallible Furies!

It was not that long ago that the omen shone forth

From the snows of Parnassus: Search everywhere for that man who is concealed;

He who wanders up to the wild-woods,

Through caves and among the rocks like some bull—

He unlucky in his desolation who by his unlucky feet

Seeks to elude that prophecy from the Temple at the centre of the world—

That living doom which circles around him.

There is a strange wonder—wrought by he who is skilled in augury;

I cannot believe, yet cannot disbelieve, nor explain my confusion

For fear hovers over me. I cannot see what is here, or what is behind!

Yet—if there was between the family of Labdacus,

And that son of Polybus, any strife existing

Either now or before, I have not learned of it

To thus use it as proof to examine by trial and thus attack

The public reputation of Oedipus, becoming thus for the family of Labdacus

Their ally in respect of that killing which has been concealed.

Rather—this is for Zeus and Apollo, who have the skill

To understand, although that other man has won more

For his discoveries than I.

Even so, on some things nothing decisive is discovered:

As in learning, where by learning

One man may overtake another.

Thus not before I see that they who accuse him are speaking straight

Will I declare myself for them

For she was visible—that winged girl who came down against him—

And we then saw proof of his knowledge, which was beneficial to our clan.

So therefore my decision is not to condemn him as ignoble.

[*Enter Creon*]

CREON

Clansmen! Having learnt of a horrible accusation

Made against me by Oedipus the King

I hastened here! If, in these our troubles,

He deems that he has suffered because of me—

Been injured by some word or some deed—

Then I would have no desire to live as long as I might

Having to bear such talk! For it is not simple—

The damage that would be done to me by such words:

Rather, it would be great, for I would be dishonoured before my clan—

With you and my kinsfolk hearing my name dishonoured.

CHORUS

That insult perhaps came forth because of anger—

Rather than being a conclusion from reason.

CREON

And it was declared that it was my reasoning

Which persuaded the prophet to utter false words?

CHORUS

It was voiced—but I do not know for what reason.

CREON

Were his eyes straight, was he thinking straight

When he made that allegation against me?

CHORUS

I do not know. For I do not observe what my superiors do.

But here, from out of his dwelling, comes the Chief himself.

[*Enter Oedipus*]

OEDIPUS

You there! Why are you here? Have you so much face

That you dare to come to my home?

You—the one exposed as the killer of its man

And, vividly, as a robber seeking my Kingship!

In the name of the gods, tell me if it was cowardice or stupidity
That you saw in me when you resolved to undertake this!
Did you reason that I would not observe your cunning treachery—
Or, if I did learn of it, I would not defend myself?
Instead, it was senseless of you to set your hand to this—
With no crowd or comrades—and go in pursuit of authority:
That which is captured by using wealth and the crowd!

CREON

You know what you must do—in answer to your words
Be as long in hearing my reply so that you can, with knowledge, judge for yourself.

OEDIPUS

Your words are clever—but I would be mistaken to learn from you,
Since I have found how dangerous and hostile you are to me.

CREON

That is the first thing you should hear me speak about.

OEDIPUS

Do not tell me: it is that you are *not* a traitor!

CREON

If you believe that what is valuable is pride, by itself,
Without a purpose, then your judgement is not right.

OEDIPUS

And if you believe you can betray a kinsman
And escape without punishment, then your judgement is no good.

CREON

I agree that such a thing is correct—
So inform me what injury you say I have inflicted.

OEDIPUS

Did you convince me or did you not convince me that I should
Send a man to bring here that respected prophet?

CREON

I am the same person now as the one who gave that advice.

OEDIPUS

How long is the duration since Laius—

CREON

Since he did what? I do not understand.

OEDIPUS

Since he disappeared: removed by deadly force?

CREON

The measurement of that duration is great—far into the past.

OEDIPUS

So—was that prophet then at his art?

CREON

Yes: of equal skill and having the same respect as now.

OEDIPUS

At that period did he make mention of me?

CREON

Certainly not to me nor when I was standing nearby.

OEDIPUS

Was there no inquiry held about the killing?

CREON

It was indeed undertaken, although nothing was learned.

OEDIPUS

So why did that clever person not speak, then?

CREON

I do not know. And about things I cannot judge for myself, I prefer to be silent.

OEDIPUS

But you do know why and would say it if you had good judgement!

CREON

What? If I did know, then I would not deny it.

OEDIPUS

It is that if he had not met with you,

He would not have spoken about "my" killing of Laius.

CREON

You should know if he indeed said that.

Now, however, it is fair that I question you just as you have me.

OEDIPUS

Question me well—for you will never convict me as the killer!

CREON

Nevertheless. You had my sister—took her as wife?

OEDIPUS

That is an assertion that cannot be denied.

CREON

Does she, in this land, possess an authority the equal of yours?

OEDIPUS

Whatsoever is her wish, she obtains from me.

CREON

And am I—who completes the triad—not the equal of you both?

OEDIPUS

And it because of that, that you are exposed as a traitor to your kin!

CREON

No! For consider these reasons for yourself, as I have,

Examining this first: do you believe anyone

Would prefer authority with all its problems

To untroubled calm if they retained the same superiority?

I myself do not nurture such a desire

To be King rather than do the deeds of a King:

No one commanding good judgement would, whoever they were.

Now, and from you, I receive everything with no problems

But if the authority was mine, I would have to do many things against my nature.

How then could being a King bring me more pleasure

Than the trouble-free authority and power I have?

I am not yet so much deceived

As to want honours other than those which profit me.

Now, I greet everyone, and now, everyone bids me well

Just as, now, those who want something from you call upon me

Since only in that way can they possibly have success.

Why, then, would I let go of these to accept that?

A traitor cannot, because of his way of thinking, have good judgement.

I am not a lover of those whose nature is to reason so

And would not endure them if they did act.

As proof of this, first go yourself to Pytho

To inquire whether the message I brought from the oracle there was true

And if you detect that I and that interpreter of signs

Plotted together, then kill me—not because of a single vote,

But because of two, for you will receive mine as well as yours.

I should not be accused because of unclear reasoning and that alone.

It is not fair when the ignoble, rashly,

Are esteemed as worthy or the worthy as ignoble.

I say that to cast away an honourable friend is to do the same

To that which is with life and which you cherish the most.

It takes a while for an intuition to be made steady

For it is only after a while that a man shows if he is fair

Although an ignoble one is known as such in a day.

CHORUS

Honourable words from someone cautious of falling,

My Lord. Those swift in their judgement are unsteady.

OEDIPUS

But when there is a plot against me which is swiftly and furtively

Moving forward, then I must be swift in opposing that plot

Since if I remain at rest, then indeed

What is about to be done, will be—because of my mistake.

CREON

Then you still desire to cast me from this land?

OEDIPUS

Not so! It is your death, not your exile, that I want!

CREON

When you explain to me what is the nature of this thing "envy"—

OEDIPUS

You speak without yielding and not in good faith!

CREON

Is it not your 'good judgement' that is keenly being observed?

OEDIPUS

But at least it is mine!

CREON

And for that very reason it is but the equal of mine.

OEDIPUS

But you have a treacherous nature!

CREON

But if nothing has been proved—

OEDIPUS

Even so, there must be authority.

CREON

Not when that authority is defective.

OEDIPUS

My clan! My clan!

CREON

A portion of the clan is for me—not wholly for you!

CHORUS

My Lords, stop this! It is fortunate perhaps that I observe
Jocasta approaching from her dwelling, since it is fitting for her
To make right the quarrel which now excites you.

[Enter Jocasta]

JOCASTA

You wretches! Why this ill-advised strife
Produced by your tongues? Are you not dishonoured—when this land
Is suffering—by becoming moved by personal troubles?
You should go within; while you, Creon, should go to your dwelling
So as not to let what is only nothing become a great sorrow.

CREON

My kin by blood! It is horrible what your husband Oedipus,
From two unfair things, has decided it is right to do!
To push me from this land of my ancestors—or to seize and kill me!

OEDIPUS

Yes! For he was, my lady, caught trying to injure
My person by a cowardly art.

CREON

[looking upward]

Deny me, this day, your assistance—curse and destroy me
If I committed that which I am accused of doing!

JOCASTA

Before the god, trust him, Oedipus!
Chiefly because of this oath to the god
And then because of me and these others here beside you.

CHORUS

My Lord—be persuaded, having agreed to reflect on this.

OEDIPUS

To what do you wish me to yield?

CHORUS

Respect he who before has never been weak—he now strengthened by that oath.

OEDIPUS

Do you know what it is that you so desire?

CHORUS

I do know.

OEDIPUS

Then explain what you believe it to be.

CHORUS

When a comrade is under oath, you should never accuse him

Because of unproved rumours and brand him as being without honour.

OEDIPUS

Then attend to this well. When you seek this, it is my

Destruction that is sought—or exile from this land.

CHORUS

No! By the god who is Chief of all the gods—

Helios! Bereft of gods, bereft of kin—may the extremist death

Of all be mine if such a judgement was ever mine!

But ill-fated would be my breath of life—which the decay in this soil

Already wears down—if to those troubles of old

There was joined this trouble between you and him.

OEDIPUS

Then allow him to go—although it requires my certain death

Or that I, without honour and by force, am thrown out from this land.

And it is because of you, not because of him—the mercy coming from your mouth—

That I do this. As for him—wherever he goes—I will detest him!

CREON

It is clear that you are hostile as you yield—and so dangerous, even though

Your anger has gone. For natures such as yours

Are deservedly painful to those who endure them.

OEDIPUS

Then go away and leave me.

CREON

I shall depart. To you, I remain unknown—but to these, here, I am the same.

[*Exit Creon*]

CHORUS

My Lady—why do you delay in returning with him into your dwelling?

JOCASTA

Because I wish to learn what has happened.

CHORUS

Suspicion arising from unreasonable talk—and a wounding that was unfair.

JOCASTA

From both of them?

CHORUS

Indeed.

JOCASTA

What was the talk?

CHORUS

Too much for me, too much for this land, wearied before this.

Since it appears to have ceased, here—let it remain so.

OEDIPUS

Observe where you have come to with your prowess in reason

By me giving way and blunting my passion!

CHORUS

My Lord, I will not say this only this once:

My judgement would be defective—and by my purposeless judgements

Would be shown to be so—if I deserted you,

You who when this land I love was afflicted

And despairing, set her straight.

Now be for us our lucky escort, again!

JOCASTA

My Lord—before the god explain to me

What act roused such wrath and made you hold onto it.

OEDIPUS

It will be told. For I respect you, my lady, more than them.

It was Creon—the plot he had against me.

JOCASTA

Then speak about it—if you can clearly affix blame for the quarrel.

OEDIPUS

He declared that it was me who had killed Laius.

JOCASTA

Did he see it, for him self—or learn of it from someone?

OEDIPUS

It was rather that he let that treacherous prophet bring it—

So as to make his own mouth entirely exempt.

JOCASTA

Therefore, and this day, acquit yourself of what was spoken about

And listen to me, for you will learn for yourself

That no mortal is given the skill to make prophecies.

I bring to light evidence for this:

An oracle came to Laius once—not I say

From Phoebus himself but from a servant—

That his own death was destined to come from a child

Which he and I would produce.

But—as it was reported—one day foreign robbers
Slew him where three cart-tracks meet.
As to the child—his growth had not extended to the third day
When we yoked the joints of its feet
And threw it—by another’s hand—upon a desolate mountain.
So, in those days, Apollo did not bring about, for him,
That he slay the father who begot him—nor, for Laius,
That horror which he feared—being killed by his son.
Such were the limits set by those words of revelation!
Therefore, do not concern yourself with them: for what a god
Wants others to find out, he will by himself unmistakably reveal.

OEDIPUS

As I heard you just now my lady,
My judgement became muddled as the breath of life left me.

JOCASTA

What has so divided you that you turn away to speak?

OEDIPUS

I believed I heard this from you—that Laius
Was killed near where three cart-tracks meet.

JOCASTA

It was, indeed, voiced—and is so, still.

OEDIPUS

Where is the place where came his misfortune?

JOCASTA

The nearby land of Phocis—where the track splits
To come from Delphi and from Daulia.

OEDIPUS

How many seasons have passed since that thing was done?

JOCASTA

It was just before you held this land's authority

That it was revealed by a herald to the clan.

OEDIPUS

O Zeus! What was your purpose in doing this to me?

JOCASTA

What is it that burdens your heart, Oedipus?

OEDIPUS

Do not enquire yet; rather, explain to me the appearance Laius had:

Was he at the height of his vigour?

JOCASTA

He was big—his head covered in hair but having a recent whiteness.

His build was not far removed from your own.

OEDIPUS

Wretch that I am! For it seems that over myself

I, without looking, threw that terrible curse!

JOCASTA

What are you saying? My Lord—I tremble as I look at you.

OEDIPUS

My courage is replaced by fear—that the prophet possesses sight!

More can be explained—if you make known one more thing.

JOCASTA

Though I still tremble, if I have knowledge of what you ask, I shall speak it.

OEDIPUS

Did he have a slender one—or did he have many men

As escort as befits a warrior chieftain?

JOCASTA

Altogether there were five, one of those being an official—

And one carriage, which conveyed Laius.

OEDIPUS

Now it becomes visible. But who was he,

My lady, who gave you that report?

JOCASTA

A servant—the very person who alone returned, having escaped harm.

OEDIPUS

Then perhaps he is to be found, at this moment, within our dwelling?

JOCASTA

Definitely not. For as soon as he returned here again and saw you

Were the master of what the dead Laius had held,

He beseeched me—his hand touching mine—

To send him away to the wilds as a shepherd to a herd,

Far away where he could not see the town.

And so I sent him. For I deemed him worthy,

As a slave, to have a greater reward than that favour.

OEDIPUS

Then swiftly—and with no delay—can he be returned here?

JOCASTA

He is around. But why do you desire it?

OEDIPUS

I fear, my lady, that far too much has already

Been said by me. Yet it is my wish to see him.

JOCASTA

Then he shall be here. But it merits me to learn,

My Lord, what burden within you is so difficult to bear.

OEDIPUS

I shall not deprive you of that—for what I fear

Comes closer. Who is more important to me than you

To whom I would speak when going through such an event as this?

Polybus the Corinthian was my father—

And the Dorian, Meropè, my mother. I was, in merit,
Greater than the clansfolk there—until I was, by chance,
Attacked. This, for me, was worthy of my wonder
Although unworthy of my zeal:
At a feast a man overfull with wine
Mumbled into his chalice what I was falsely said to be my father's.
I was annoyed by this during that day—scarcely able
To hold myself back. On the one following that, I sought to question
My mother and father, and they were indignant
At he who had let loose those words at me.
Because of this, I was glad, although I came to itch from them
For much did they slither about.
So, unobserved by my mother and father, I travelled
To Pytho. But for that which I had come, Phoebus there
Did not honour me; instead—suffering and strangeness
And misery were what his words foresaw:
That I must copulate with my mother—and show,
For mortals to behold, a family who would not endure—
And also be the killer of the father who planted me.
I, after hearing this—and regarding Corinth—
Thereafter by the stars measured the ground
I fled upon so that I would never have to face—
Because of that inauspicious prophecy—the disgrace of its fulfilment.
And while so travelling I arrived in those regions
Where you spoke of the King himself being killed.
For you, my lady, I shall declare what has not been spoken of before.
While journeying, I came near to that three-fold track,
And at that place an official and a carriage
With young horse with a man mounted in it—such as you spoke of—

Came toward me. And he who was in front as well as the Elder himself

Were for driving me vigorously from the path.

But the one who had pushed me aside—the carriage driver—

I hit in anger: and the Elder, observing this

From his chariot, watched for me to go past and then on the middle

Of my head struck me with his forked goad.

He was certainly repaid with more! By a quick blow

From the staff in this, my hand, he fell back

From the middle of the carriage and rolled straight out!

And then I destroyed all the others. Yet if to that stranger

And Laius there belongs a common relation

Then who exists who is now as unfortunate as this man, here?

Who of our race of mortals would have a daimon more hostile—

He to whom it is not permitted for a stranger nor a clansman

To receive into their homes, nor even speak to—

But who, instead, must be pushed aside? And it is such things as these—

These curses!—that I have brought upon myself.

The wife of he who is dead has been stained by these hands

Which killed him. Was I born ignoble?

Am I not wholly unclean? For I must be exiled

And in my exile never see my family

Nor step into my own fatherland—or by marriage

I will be yoked to my mother and slay my father

Polybus, he who produced and nourished me.

And would not someone who decided a savage daimon

Did these things to me be speaking correctly?

You awesome, powerful, gods—

May I never see that day! May I go away

From mortals, unobserved, before I see

The stain of that misfortune come to me.

CHORUS

I also, my Lord, would wish to draw away from such things.

But surely until you learn from he who was there, you can have expectations?

OEDIPUS

Indeed. There is for me just such an expectation,

And one alone—to wait for that herdsman.

JOCASTA

And when he does appear, what is your intent?

OEDIPUS

I will explain it to you. If his report is found to be

The same as yours, then I shall escape that suffering.

JOCASTA

Did you then hear something odd in my report?

OEDIPUS

You said he spoke of men—of robbers—being the ones

Who did the killing. If, therefore, he still

Speaks of there being many of them, then I am not the killer

For one cannot be the same as the many of that kind.

But if he says a solitary armed traveller, then it is clear,

And points to me as the person who did that work.

JOCASTA

You should know that it was announced in that way.

He cannot go back and cast them away

For they were heard, here, by the clan—not just by me.

Yet even if he turns away from his former report,

Never, my Lord, can the death of Laius

Be revealed as a straight fit—for it was Loxias

Who disclosed he would be killed by the hand of my child.

But he—the unlucky one—could not have slain him

For he was himself destroyed before that.

Since then I have not by divination looked into

What is on either side of what is next.

OEDIPUS

I find that pleasing. However, that hired hand

Should be summoned here by sending someone—it should not be neglected.

JOCASTA

I will send someone, and swiftly. But let us go into our dwelling.

I would not do anything that would be disagreeable to you.

[*Exit Oedipus and Jocasta*]

CHORUS

May the goddess of destiny be with me

So that I bear an entirely honourable attitude

In what I say and in what I do—

As set forth above us in those customs born and

Given their being in the brightness of the heavens

And fathered only by Olympus.

For they were not brought forth by mortals,

Whose nature is to die. Not for them the lethargy

Of laying down to sleep

Since the god within them is strong, and never grows old.

Insolence plants the tyrant:

There is insolence if by a great foolishness

There is a useless over-filling which goes beyond

The proper limits—

It is an ascending to the steepest and utmost heights

And then that hurtling toward that Destiny

Where the useful foot has no use.

Yet since it is good for a clan to have combat,
I ask the god never to deliver us from it:
As may I never cease from having the god for my champion.
If someone goes forth and by his speaking
Or the deeds of his hands looks down upon others
With no fear of the goddess Judgement and not in awe
Of daimons appearing,
Then may he be seized by a destructive Fate
Because of his unlucky weakness.
If he does not gain what he gains fairly,
Does not keep himself from being disrespectful,
And in his foolishness holds onto what should not be touched,
Then how will such a man thereafter keep away those arrows of anger
Which will take revenge on his breath of life?
For if such actions are those are esteemed,
Is this my respectful choral-dance required?
No more would I go in awe to that never to be touched sacred-stone,
Nor to that Temple at Abae,
Nor Olympia—if those prophecies do not fit
In such a way that all mortals can point it out.
But you whom it is right to call my master—
Zeus!—you who rule over everyone: do not forget this,
You whose authority is, forever, immortal.
For they begin to decay—those prophecies of Laius
Given long ago, and are even now set aside
And nowhere does Apollo become manifest because esteemed:
For the rituals of the gods are being lost.

[*Enter Jocasta*]

JOCASTA

Lords of this land—the belief has been given to me
That I should go to the Temples of our guardian gods, my hands
Holding a garland and an offering of incense.
For Oedipus lets his breath of life be too much possessed by his heart
Because of all his afflictions—since, unlike a man who reasons
And determines the limits of what is strange by the past,
He is fearful when someone, in speaking, speaks of such things.
Therefore, since none of my counsels have achieved anything,
I come here—to you, Lycean Apollo, since you are close to us—
To petition you by asking you with these my gifts
That we are cleansed of defilement by you bringing us deliverance.
For now all of us are afraid as we behold
That he who is guiding our vessel is wounded.

[Enter Messenger]

MESSENGER

Is it from you, stranger, that I might learn where
Is the dwelling of King Oedipus:
Or, more particularly, if you have knowledge of where he himself is?

CHORUS

Here are his chambers, stranger, and he himself is within.
But here is his wife and mother of his children.

MESSENGER

May she always prosper in her prospering descent
Since by them her marriage is complete.

JOCASTA

And may you, also, stranger, because of your worthy eloquence.
But explain to me what you seek in arriving here
Or what it is that you wish to make known.

MESSENGER

What is profitable, my lady, for both your family and your husband.

JOCASTA

What is it? And who sent you here, to us?

MESSENGER

I am from Corinth. And when, presently, I have said my speech,

There will be joy—of that I have no doubt—but also an equal sorrowing.

JOCASTA

How can that be? What has a double strength that it could cause that?

MESSENGER

He, as their King: for they who inhabit the land

Of Isthmia would make him so—so they have said.

JOCASTA

How is that? For is not Polybus, the Elder, their Master?

MESSENGER

Not now—because death holds him in a tomb.

JOCASTA

What are you saying? That the father of Oedipus—has died?

MESSENGER

Is my report is not correct, then I merit death.

JOCASTA

Swiftly—my handmaiden—go to your master

To tell him this. You prophecies from the gods!—

Where is your reality? This was the man whom Oedipus long ago from fear

Avoided lest he kill him. And now it is because

Of his own destiny that he died rather than through that of another.

[*Enter Oedipus*]

OEDIPUS

My Lady, Jocasta:

Why did you summon me here from my chamber?

JOCASTA

Hear this man and, as you listen, watch to where

It is that those solemn prophecies of the gods lead.

OEDIPUS

What report has he—wherever he is from—for me?

JOCASTA

He is from Corinth with the message that your father

Polybus is no more—he is dead.

OEDIPUS

Then announce it, stranger—leading it out yourself, old one.

MESSENGER

If that is what I must relate first and clearly

Then know well that his death has come upon him.

OEDIPUS

Was it by treachery—or by dealing with sickness?

MESSENGER

A small turn downwards, and the ageing body lies in sleep.

OEDIPUS

Am I to assume that he unfortunately perished from a sickness?

MESSENGER

Indeed—for he had been allocated a great many seasons.

OEDIPUS

Ah! Then why, my lady, look toward

The altar of some Pythian prophet, or above to those

Screeching birds—whose guidance was that I would

Assuredly kill my father? But he is dead

And hidden within the earth, while I am here

Without having to clean my spear. Unless—it was a longing for me

Which destroyed him, and thus he is dead because of me.

But then—that divine prophecy has been, by that circumstance, taken away

By Polybus lying in Hades, and thus has no importance.

JOCASTA

Did I not declare such things to you, just now?

OEDIPUS

Such was said—but I turned away because of my fear of them.

JOCASTA

Do not anymore wound your heart by such things.

OEDIPUS

But how can I not distance myself from that intercourse with my mother?

JOCASTA

What is there for mortals to fear, for it is chance

Which rules over them, and who can clearly foresee what does not exist?

It is most excellent to live without a plan—according to one's ability.

You should not fear being married to your mother:

For many are the mortals who have—in dreams also—

Lain with their mothers, and he to whom such things as these

Are as nothing, provides himself with a much easier life.

OEDIPUS

All that you expressed is fine, except for this:

She who gave me birth is alive, and since she is now still living,

It is necessary that I—despite your fine words—distance myself from her.

JOCASTA

Yet the death of your father is a great revelation for you.

OEDIPUS

Yes—a great one. But I fear she who is living.

MESSENGER

Who is this woman that you so fear?

OEDIPUS

Meropè, old one: she who belonged with Polybus.

MESSENGER

And what, concerning her, could produce fear in you?

OEDIPUS

A strange god-inspired prophecy.

MESSENGER

Is it forbidden for someone else to know—or can it be told?

OEDIPUS

Certainly. Once, Loxias said to me

That I must copulate with my own mother

And by my own hands take my father's blood.

Therefore, and long ago, I left Corinth

And have kept far away from there. And good fortune has been mine,

Although it is very pleasing to behold the eye's of one's parents.

MESSENGER

Was that what distanced you from your clan?

OEDIPUS

Yes, old one: I did not want to slaughter my father.

MESSENGER

Then why, my Lord, have I not released you from that fear—

Since I came here as a favour to you?

OEDIPUS

Certainly you would merit receiving a reward from me.

MESSENGER

And that was chiefly why I came here—

That on your arrival home I would obtain something useful.

OEDIPUS

But I will not rejoin those who planted me.

MESSENGER

My son! It is clearly evident you cannot see what you are doing—

OEDIPUS

Why, old one? Before the gods, enlighten me!

MESSENGER

—If it was because of that, that you avoided returning to your home.

OEDIPUS

Yes, out of respect for Phoebus so that what he explained could not be fulfilled.

MESSENGER

A defilement brought to you by they who planted you?

OEDIPUS

That, Elder, is the thing I have always feared.

MESSENGER

Then you should know that there is nothing to make you tremble.

OEDIPUS

Nothing? Why—if I was the child born to them?

MESSENGER

Because you and Polybus are not kin by blood.

OEDIPUS

Are you saying that Polybus did not sire me?

MESSENGER

The same as but no more than this man, here!

OEDIPUS

How can he who sired me be the same as he who did not?

MESSENGER

Because he did not beget you—as I did not.

OEDIPUS

But then why did he name me as his son?

MESSENGER

Know that you were accepted from my hands as a gift.

OEDIPUS

And he strongly loved what came from the hand of another?

MESSENGER

He was persuaded because before then he was without children.

OEDIPUS

When I was given to him—had you purchased or begotten me?

MESSENGER

You were found in a forest valley on Cithaeron.

OEDIPUS

And why were you travelling in that region?

MESSENGER

I was there to oversee the mountain sheep.

OEDIPUS

A shepherd—who wandered in search of work?

MESSENGER

Yes—and that season the one who, my son, was your saviour.

OEDIPUS

What ailment possessed me when you took me into your hands?

MESSENGER

The joints of your feet are evidence of it.

OEDIPUS

What makes you speak of that old defect?

MESSENGER

I undid what held and pierced your ankles.

OEDIPUS

A strange disgrace—to carry such a token with me.

MESSENGER

Such was the fortune that named you who you are.

OEDIPUS

Before the gods, tell me whether that thing was done by my father or my mother.

MESSENGER

I do not know—he who gave you to me would be the best judge of that.

OEDIPUS

What? From someone else? Then it was not by chance you found me?

MESSENGER

No—another shepherd gave you to me.

OEDIPUS

Who was it? Can you point him out? Tell whom you saw?

MESSENGER

He was perhaps named among those of Laius.

OEDIPUS

He who once and long ago was King of this land?

MESSENGER

Yes—that man was his shepherd.

OEDIPUS

Is he then still living? Is it possible for me to see him?

MESSENGER

You who are of this region would know that best.

OEDIPUS

Is there among you here, anyone

Whoever he might be, who knows this shepherd he speaks of

Or who has seen him either here or in the wilds?

If so, declare it—for here is the opportunity to find out about these things.

CHORUS

I believe he is that one in the wilds

Whom you sought before to see.

But it is Jocasta—for certain—who could tell of him.

OEDIPUS

My lady—do you know if it is he who, before,

We desired to return to here? Is that the one about whom this person speaks?

JOCASTA

The one he spoke about? Why? Do not return to it

Nor even desire to attend again to this idle talk!

OEDIPUS

It could never be that I would fail to grasp

These proofs which will shed light upon my origin.

JOCASTA

Before the gods! If you value your own life,

Do not seek that. I have enough pain now.

OEDIPUS

Have courage—for even if my three mothers past

Were shown to be three slaves, you would not be the one exposed as low-born.

JOCASTA

I beseech you to be persuaded by me. Do not do this.

OEDIPUS

I cannot be persuaded not to learn of this for certain.

JOCASTA

Yet my judgement is for your good—it is said for the best.

OEDIPUS

This “for the best” pained me before and does so again.

JOCASTA

You, the unlucky one—may you never find out who you are.

OEDIPUS

Someone go and bring that Shepherd here to me,

For she can still rejoice in her distinguished origins.

JOCASTA

You are doomed: this and this alone will I

Say to you—and nothing hereafter!

[*Exit Jocasta*]

CHORUS

Why, Oedipus, has your lady gone, taken away

By some wild affliction? I am in awe

Of a misfortune bursting forth because of her silence about this.

OEDIPUS

It is necessary that it does burst forth. However lowly

My seed may be, it is my wish to know about it.

Although she is a woman, she has a mature judgement—

But even so, perhaps she is ashamed of my low-born origins.

But I—who apportion myself a child of the goddess, Fortuna,

She of beneficence—will not become dishonoured,

For She was the mother who gave me birth: my kinsfolk

The moons which separated my greatness and my lowness.

As this is the nature of my being, I cannot ever go away from it

To another, and so not learn about my birth.

CHORUS

If indeed I am a prophet or skillful in reason,

Then—by Olympus!—you shall not be without the experience,

O Cithaeron, on the rising of the full moon,

Of me exalting you—the kinsfolk of Oedipus,

His mother and provider—by my choral-dance

Since a joy has been brought to my King.

Phoebus—I invoke you, that this may also be pleasing to you!

Who, my son, of those whose living in years is long,

Did the mountain-wanderer Pan come down upon

To be your father? Or was it Loxias who slept with a woman?

For agreeable to him are all those who inhabit the wilds!

Or perhaps it was he who is the sovereign of Cyllene:

Or he the mountain-summit dwelling god of those Bacchinities

Who gladly received you who was found by one of those Helicon Nymphs

With whom he so often plays!

OEDIPUS

If it fitting for me—who has never had dealings with him—

To make an estimate, Elders, then I believe I see that Shepherd

Whom we sought before. For his great age

Would conform and be in accord with that of this man.

Also, those who are escorting him are servants

Of my own family. But, about this, your experience

Has the advantage over mine since you have seen that Shepherd before.

CHORUS

I see him clearly—and, yes, I know him. For if Laius ever had

A faithful Shepherd, it was this man.

[Enter Shepherd]

OEDIPUS

You, the stranger from Corinth, I question you first—

Is this he whom you talked about.

MESSENGER

Indeed—you behold him.

OEDIPUS

You there, old man! Here, look at me, and answer

My questions. Did you once belong to Laius?

SHEPHERD

Yes—nourished by him, not purchased as a slave.

OEDIPUS

What work did you share in or was your livelihood?

SHEPHERD

For the greater part, my living was the way of a shepherd.

OEDIPUS

And in what region did you mostly dwell with them?

SHEPHERD

It was Cithaeron—and also neighbouring regions.

OEDIPUS

This man here—did you ever observe him there and come to know him?

SHEPHERD

Doing what? Which is the man you speak of?

OEDIPUS

This one, standing there. Did you have dealings with him?

SHEPHERD

Not as I recall—so as to speak about now.

MESSENGER

That is no wonder, your Lordship. But I shall bring light

Upon those things which are now unknown. For well do I know

That he will see again that region of Cithaeron when he

With a double flock and I with one

Were neighbours and comrades for three entire six month

Durations from Spring to Arcturus.

Then for the Winter I would drive mine to my stables

And he, his, to the pens of Laius.

Was this, of which I have spoken, done or not as I have spoken?

SHEPHERD

Your words disclose it—although it is from long ago.

MESSENGER

Well, now say you know that you offered me a boy,

A nursling to rear as my own.

SHEPHERD

What do you mean? What do you ask me for?

MESSENGER

This, sir, is he who was that youngster!

SHEPHERD

May misfortune come to you! Why do you not keep silent?

OEDIPUS

You—old man. Do not restrain him for it is your speech

Which should be more restrained, not his.

SHEPHERD

Most noble Lord—what is my fault?

OEDIPUS

In not telling of the child he asked about.

SHEPHERD

But he speaks without looking as he toils without an aim.

OEDIPUS

If you will not speak as a favour, you will when you cry-out.

SHEPHERD

Before the gods, do not strike someone who is old.

OEDIPUS

Swiftly, one of you, twist his hands behind his back.

SHEPHERD

You unlucky one! What more do you desire to learn from me?

OEDIPUS

Did you give him that child he asked about?

SHEPHERD

I did. And it would have been to my advantage to die that day.

OEDIPUS

It will come to that if your words are not true.

SHEPHERD

Yet much more will be destroyed if I do speak.

OEDIPUS

This man, it seems, pushes for a delay.

SHEPHERD

I do not. Just now I said I gave him.

OEDIPUS

Taken from where? Your abode—or from that of another?

SHEPHERD

Not from my own; I received him from someone.

OEDIPUS

Who—of these clansmen here? From whose dwelling?

SHEPHERD

Your lordship, before the gods do not ask me more.

OEDIPUS

You die if I have to put that question to you again.

SHEPHERD

Then—it was one of those fathered by Laius.

OEDIPUS

From a slave? Or born from one of his own race?

SHEPHERD

Ah! Here before me is what I dread. Of speaking it...

OEDIPUS

And I, of hearing it, although hear it I must.

SHEPHERD

It was said to be his own child. But of these things,

It is your lady—who is within—who could best speak of them.

OEDIPUS

Why? Because she gave it to you?

SHEPHERD

Indeed, Lord.

OEDIPUS

Why did she want that?

SHEPHERD

So it would be destroyed.

OEDIPUS

How grievous for she who bore the child!

SHEPHERD

Yes—but she dreaded divine prophecies of ill-omen.

OEDIPUS

Which were?

SHEPHERD

The word was that he would kill his parents.

OEDIPUS

Then why did you let this elderly one take him.

MESSENGER

Because, your lordship, of mercy—so that to another land

He might fittingly convey it: to where he himself came from.

But he saved him for this mighty wound. If then you are

The one he declares you to be, know how unlucky was your birth!

OEDIPUS

Ah! All that was possible has, with certainty, passed away.

You—daylight—I now look my last at what I behold by you:

I, exposed as born from those who should not have borne me—

As having been intimate with those I should not, and killed those I should not.

[Exit Oedipus, Shepherd and Messenger]

CHORUS

You descendants of mortals—

I count your zest as being equivalent to nothing,

For where is the person
Who has won more from a lucky daimon
Than just that appearance of fame
Which later is peeled away?
Yours—your daimon, Oedipus the unlucky—
We hold as an example
That nothing mortal is favoured.
For, O Zeus, it was beyond the bounds of others
That he shot his arrow to win
An all-prospering lucky daimon:
He who in destroying that virginal chantress of oracles
With the curved claws,
Arose in my country as a defence against death.
And who since then has been called my Lord
And greatly honoured as the chief of Thebes the magnificent!
But now—who has heard of a greater misfortune?
Who is there so savagely ruined that he dwells with such troubles
With his life so changed?
Alas—Oedipus, the renowned! A mature haven
Was enough for you
As child and father when you fell upon
That woman in her inner chamber!
How, how could what your father pushed into
Have the vigour for you for so long and in silence?
Chronos, the all-seeing, has found you, beyond your own will,
For long ago it was determined that from that marriage which was no marriage
Those children who have been born were the children that would be born.
But—as being the son of Laius,
I wish, I wish that I had never known this.

For I lament, and my cry is above all the others

As it comes forth from my mouth.

To speak straight: you gave me breath again

But I allowed my eyes to sleep.

[Enter Second Messenger]

MESSENGER

You who in this land have always been esteemed the most!

What deeds you are to hear—what behold!—and how much grief

Will weigh upon you if, on fidelity to your origins,

Your concern is still for the family of Labdacus!

For, alas, neither the Ister nor the Phasis

Can wash clean these chambers, so much suffering

Do they conceal—soon to be exposed to the light

As willed, not done outside the aid of will. Those injuries

Which bring the most grieving, are those shown to be of our own choice.

CHORUS

What I knew before could not fail to make my grieving

Anything but grave; after that—what could you announce?

MESSENGER

What is a quick tale to say

And to understand: the divinity, Jocasta, is dead.

CHORUS

A misfortune! From what cause?

MESSENGER

By she herself. But, of those events,

What was most painful is not for you—for you did not view them.

Yet—as long as my Muse is with me—

You can learn of the sufferings of her fate.

She—coloured by emotion—passed within the hall

To run straight to that bridal-bed of hers
Tearing at her hair with the fingers of both her hands.
Then, she went within—thrusting the doors closed—
To invoke Laius, he who long ago was a corpse,
Recalling that seed she received long ago by which
He was killed, to leave her to produce
Unlucky children from his own begotten child.
She lamented the bed of her double misfortune:
From her husband, a husband—and children from that child.
How, after that, she perished, I did not see
For with a war-cry Oedipus pushed in—and, because of him,
We did not behold the end of her suffering.
To him, we looked as he ploughed around
For wildly he ranged about, demanding his spear,
His lady who was not his lady, and where he might find that maternal
Double-womb which produced he himself and his children.
He was frenzied, and a daimon guided him—
For it was no man who was standing nearby—
And with a fearful shout—as if someone led the way—
He was propelled into those double-doors and, from their supports,
Bent those hollow barriers to fall into her chamber.
And there we beheld that lady suspended
In the swinging braided cords by which she had stricken herself.
He, seeing this, with a fearful roar of grief
Let down the cords which suspended her. Then when she the unfortunate
Was lain on the ground, there was something dreadful to behold:
For he tore from her those gold brooches
With which she had adorned herself
And raised them to assault his own circular organs,

Speaking such as this: that they would not have sight of
Those troubles he had suffered or had caused
But would henceforth and in darkness have sight of what
They should not and what he himself should not have had knowledge of.
Then with a awesome lament not once but frequently
He raised them to strike into his eyes. At each, blood
From his eyes dropped to his beard, not releasing blood
Drop by drop—but all at once:
A dark storm hailing drops of blood.
From those two has this burst forth—not on one
But on that man and his lady, joined by these troubles.
That old prosperity anciently theirs was indeed once
A worthy prosperity—but now, on this day, there is
Lamentation, misfortune, death, disgrace, and of all those troubles
That exist and which have names, there is not one which is not here.

CHORUS

Does he who suffers now rest from injury?

MESSENGER

He shouts for the barriers to be opened to expose
To all who are of Cadmus, this patricide,
This mother...—I will not say the profanity he speaks—
So he can cast himself from this land, and not remain
For this dwelling to become cursed because of his curse.
But he requires strength and a guide
For too great for him to carry is that burden
Which he will make known to you. You will behold a spectacle
Which even those to whom it is horrible, will make lament for.

[Enter the blind Oedipus]

CHORUS

How strange for mortals to see such an accident as this!

It is the strangest thing of all ever

To come before me. You—who suffer this—

What fury came upon you? What daimon

With great leaps from a great height

Came upon you bringing such an unfortunate fate?

I lament for your bad-luck.

Though I am not able to look at you—

There is much I wish to ask, much to understand,

Much to know

Even though I am here, shivering.

OEDIPUS

I am in agony!

To where, in my misery, am I carried? To where

Is my voice conveyed as it flees from me?

You—that daimon! To where have you brought me?

CHORUS

Somewhere strange with nothing to be heard and nothing to be seen.

OEDIPUS

Nothing announced the arrival of this dark cloud shrouding me!

Something unconquerable—brought by an unfavourable wind.

As one do the stings of those goads,

And the recalling of those troubles, pierce me!

CHORUS

It is no surprise that because of such injuries

You endure a double mourning and a double misfortune.

OEDIPUS

My friend!

You, at least, are my steadfast comrade

Because you have the endurance to attend to the blind.

For you are not hidden from me—I clearly know,

Even in this darkness, that it is your voice.

CHORUS

You of strange deeds—how did you bear

To so extinguish your sight? What daimon carried you away?

OEDIPUS

It was Apollo—Apollo, my friend,

Who brought such troubles to such a troubled end.

But it was my own hand, and no other, which made the assault—

I, who suffer this. For why should I have sight

When there was nothing pleasing to see?

CHORUS

These things are as you have said they are.

OEDIPUS

Who could I behold?

Who could be loved—or whose greeting,

My friend, would be delightful to hear?

So, and swiftly, send me away from this place.

Send away, my friend, this great pest—

This bringer of a curse: the mortal whom our gods

Detest the most.

CHORUS

You are as helpless in that resolve as you were in your misfortune:

Thus I wish you had never come to know of those things!

OEDIPUS

May death come to whosoever while roaming those grasslands loosened

Those cruel fetters and so safely pulled me away from death!

For it was not a favourable deed.

For had I died then no grief such as this

Would have been caused to either me or my kin.

CHORUS

I also wish that.

OEDIPUS

I would not, then, have shed the blood of my father

As I journeyed, and not be named by mortals

As the husband of she who gave me my birth.

I am without a god—an unconsecrated child—

And now of the same kind as he who gave me this miserable existence!

If there is a trouble which is even older than these troubles,

Then it will be the lot of Oedipus.

CHORUS

I do not know if I could say that your intentions were right,

For it is perhaps better to no longer exist than to live, blind.

OEDIPUS

But as to this being done for the best—

You should not instruct me, nor offer me more advice.

For, if I had eyes, I would not know where to look

When I went to Hades and saw my father

Or my unfortunate mother, since to both

I have done what is so outstanding that a strangling is excluded.

Perhaps the sight of children is desirable:

To behold how those buds are mine will grow—

But it would certainly not be to these eyes of mine.

Nor would that of this town, or its towers, or the sacrifices

Offered to daimons. For it was most unfortunate that I—

Who as no one else in Thebes prospered most excellently—

Bereaved myself of such things by my own declaration

That everyone must push aside the profane one—the one the gods

Have exposed as unclean and of the clan of Laius.

After I have made known this, my stain,

How could I look those here straight in the eye?

Certainly I could not. And if what is heard could be blocked out

At that source in my ears, I would not have held myself back

From this miserable body and thus would be blind and also hear nothing!

For it is pleasing to dwell away from concern about injury.

Why, Cithaeron—why did you receive me, and having accepted,

Not directly kill me so I would never make known

To mortals whence I was born?

O Polybus and Corinth—and you that others called the ancient clan-home

Of my ancestors—I, the beauty that you reared

Had bad wounds festering underneath!

For I am found to be defective having been defective from my birth.

You three routes and concealed valley,

You grove and narrow place of the three-fold paths:

You took in from my hands that blood which was my father's

But also mine—so perhaps you can still recall

Those deeds that I did there, and then, when here,

What I also achieved? You—those rites of joy

Which gave me my birth and which planted me anew

By the same seed being shot up to manifest fathers,

Brothers, sons—the blood of a kinsman—

Brides, wives, mothers: as much shame

As can arise from deeds among mortals.

No one should speak about things they do not favour doing.

Swiftly then—before the gods and beyond here—

Hide me away or kill me or upon the sea cast me

So that you will never look upon me again.

Come, and dignify this unhappy man by your touch.

Be persuaded—do not fear. For this misfortune is mine alone

And no mortal except me can bear it.

[Enter Creon]

CHORUS

As to this request of yours—it is fitting that here is Creon

To act and give advice,

For he alone is left to be guardian of this region in your place.

OEDIPUS

But what is there than I can say to him?

What trust can with fairness be shown to me?

For I am discovered as being false to him, previously, in everything.

CREON

I did not come here, Oedipus, to laugh

Nor to blame you for your previous error.

[Creon turns to speak to the crowd who have gathered]

You—there—even if you do not honour those descended from mortals,

Have respect for the all-nourishing flames of the Lord Helios

So that this stain is not looked upon when it is uncovered—

This which neither our soil nor the sacred waters

Nor daylight will welcome.

Swiftly now take him into his chambers:

For the most proper conduct is that only kinfolk

Look at and hear a kinsman's faults.

OEDIPUS

Before the gods—since you have torn from me a dread

By you coming here—you, the most noble—to me, a most ignoble man,

Yield me something. I say this not for myself, but for you.

CREON

What favour do you request so earnestly?

OEDIPUS

That you throw me from this land as swiftly as you can

To where it is known there will be not one mortal to greet me.

CREON

Know that this would certainly have been done—were it not necessary

For me first to learn from the god what I should do.

OEDIPUS

But his saying was completely clear—

That I, the disrespectful one, the patricide, must depart.

CREON

Those were the words—but since our needs have changed

It is better to learn what must be done.

OEDIPUS

But you will enquire of behalf of this unhappy man?

CREON

Yes—as you should now pay tribute to the god.

OEDIPUS

Certainly—and I rely on you for this supplication:

That you give to she who is within, a tomb such as you might desire

To lay yourself in—for it is correct to so perform this on behalf of your own.

As for me—never once let it be deemed fitting, while I happen to live,

For this my father's town to have me within it.

Instead, let me dwell in the mountains—to where is Cithaeron

Renowned because of me; for my mother and my father

While they lived appointed it the tomb I would lay in.

Thus, there I will depart, killed as they desired.

Yet I do know that neither a sickness

Nor anything similar will destroy me, for I would never have been saved

From that death unless it was for some horrible injury.

Hence I shall await that destiny which is mine—whatever its nature.

As for my sons—do not, Creon, add them

To your care. For they are men, and therefore will never

Lack the ability—wherever they are—to survive.

But as for those unfortunate ones, my girls

For whom my table of food was never separate from

Nor who were ever without me, so that whatever I touched

Would be shared between us—

Attend to them, for me.

Would that you could let my hands touch them

And they lament for my injuries.

Let these things be, Lord—

Let them be so, you of this noble race.

For if my hands could reach them

I would believe they were mine just as when I had my sight.

[Enter Antigone and Ismene]

What is this?

Before the gods!—Do I not hear those whom I love,

Weeping? Has Creon let them make lament for me,

Sending here those who are dearest to me—my daughters?

Is this right?

CREON

It is right. For I prepared this for you.

I conjectured this—your present delight—since it has possessed you before.

OEDIPUS

Then good fortune to you on your path—

And may you be guarded by a better daimon than was my fate!

My children—where are you? Come here—here

To these my hands of he who is your brother:

These of he who planted you and which assisted your father

To see in this way with what before were clear eyes.

He, my children, who sees nothing, who enquires about nothing—

He who is exposed as fathering you from where he himself was sown.

Even though I cannot behold you, I lament for you

Because I know of the bitter life left to you

Which mortals will cause you to live.

For what gathering of townsfolk could you go to?

What festivals—from where you would not return, lamenting,

To your dwelling instead of watching the spectacle?

And when you become ripe for marriage

Who is there who exists, my children, who would chance it—

Accepting the rebukes that will as painful for they who begat me

As they will be for you?

For what injury is not here? Your father killed his father;

He seeded her who had brought him forth

And from where he himself was sown

You were born—in the same way he himself was acquired.

Such as this will you be rebuked with. Who then will marry you?

Such a person does not exist. No, my children, it is without doubt

That you must go to waste unsown and unmarried.

Son of Menoeceus! You are the only father

Who is left to them, for we who planted them are destroyed:

Both of us. Watch that they do not wander

As beggars, without a man, since they are of your family—

Or that they become the equal of me in misfortune.

Rather, favour them because you see them at such an age as this,

Deserted by everyone—except for yourself.

Agree to this, noble lord, and touch me with your hand.

And you, my children—had you judgement, I would even now

Have given you much advice. As it is, let your supplication be

To live where it is allowed and to obtain a life more agreeable

Than that of the father who planted you.

CREON

Let this abundance of lamentation pass away—and go into those chambers.

OEDIPUS

I shall obey, although it is not pleasing.

CREON

All fine things have their season.

OEDIPUS

Do you know my conditions for going?

CREON

Speak them—and I, having heard them, will know.

OEDIPUS

Send me far from this land.

CREON

That gift comes from the gods.

OEDIPUS

But the gods must detest me!

CREON

Then swiftly will your wish be fulfilled.

OEDIPUS

But do you grant this?

CREON

I have no desire to speak idly about things I cannot judge.

OEDIPUS

Then now lead me from here.

CREON

Move away from your children—and go.

OEDIPUS

But do not take them from me.

CREON

Do not desire to be master in all things:

For you are without the strength which assisted you during your life.

CHORUS

You who dwell in my fatherland, Thebes, observe—here is Oedipus,

He who understood that famous enigma and was a strong man:

What clansman did not behold that fortune without envy?

But what a tide of problems have come over him!

Therefore, look toward that ending which is for us mortals

To observe that particular day—calling no one lucky until,

Without the pain of injury, they are conveyed beyond life's ending.